

Aquifer Open Study Notes

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This resource has been adapted into multiple languages, including English, Tok Pisin, Arabic (عربي), French (Français), Hindi (हिंदी), Indonesian (Bahasa Indonesia), Portuguese (Português), Russian (Русский), Spanish (Español), Swahili (Kiswahili), and Simplified Chinese (简体中文).

Luke

Luke 1:1

- Many people had already begun to write accounts of Jesus's life. Luke was not the first to write this history. Most scholars think Luke used the Gospel of Mark and other written and spoken sources.
- *fulfilled*: This word can mean “finished” or “completed,” but Luke is referring to Jesus making Old Testament promises come true ([4:21](#); [24:44](#)).

Luke 1:1–4

Luke begins his Gospel with a formal introduction written in the style of skilled Greek writers of his time. These first four verses use a careful and formal style. They are among the best-written Greek in the New Testament.

Luke 1:3

- As a good historian, Luke *carefully investigated* the history of Jesus from the start to provide a reliable story.
- *an orderly account*: Some versions translate this phrase as “in consecutive order.” But it means an organized or *carefully written account*, not a sequence of time.
- The name *Theophilus* means “loved by God” or “one who loves God.” It is likely a personal name, not meant to describe a name.

Different theories suggest he might be:

1. an unbeliever who was influential in society,
2. a person newly converted to Christianity needing guidance,
3. the judge at the apostle Paul's trial (the book of Acts ends with Paul in prison in Rome, waiting for his trial, or
4. the person who funded Luke's writing project.

The fourth option is the most likely because it was common when writing literature to honor the person who funded it. The Greek word translated as *most excellent* indicates someone of important social status.

Luke 1:5

- *Herod king of Judea*: See the profile on “Herod the Great.”
- *a priest named Zechariah*: He was a descendant of Aaron, the brother of Moses ([Exodus 28:1](#)).
- *who belonged to the priestly division of Abijah*: See the study note on Luke 1:8–9 and also [1 Chronicles 24:10](#).
- *Elizabeth was a descendant of Aaron*: Jews considered it especially spiritual for a priest to marry a woman from a priestly family.

Luke 1:5–2:52

The Gospel of Luke's first two chapters describe the birth of Jesus and introduce key themes that appear later in Luke and Acts. The announcements and birth stories of Jesus and John the Baptist appear together, emphasizing their roles in bringing God's salvation.

At each point, Luke's Gospel shows Jesus to be greater. John is the forerunner announcing the coming of Jesus, while Jesus is the Savior.

Luke 1:7

Elizabeth was barren: Giving birth to children was a woman's greatest role in this culture. Being unable to have children made women feel ashamed. God miraculously intervened in the lives of various Old Testament women so they could have children ([Genesis 18:10–12](#); [25:21](#); [30:22–23](#); [Judges 13](#); [1 Samuel 1:1–28](#)).

Luke 1:8–9

- *Zechariah's division was on duty ... he was chosen by lot*: It was common in Old Testament times to cast lots (similar to throwing dice) to determine God's will ([1 Chronicles 26:13–16](#); [Nehemiah 11:1](#); [Proverbs 16:33](#); [Jonah 1:7](#)). There were 24 orders of priests that took turns serving in the temple ([1 Chronicles 24:1–19](#)). They cast lots to choose which priest would serve in the sanctuary of the temple. There were many priests, so this honor might come only once in a priest's life. The angel appeared at the most holy moment of Zechariah's life.
- *to enter the temple of the Lord and burn incense*: Luke uses the Greek word *naos* to refer to the temple building. He did mean the whole temple complex (*hieron*), which he refers to as “the temple courts” ([Luke 2:27](#)). The temple complex included the Holy Place and the Most Holy Place (see [Hebrews 9:1–5](#)). The priests burned incense twice a day in the Holy Place.

Luke 1:12–13

- *he was startled and gripped with fear*: Fear and awe are common reactions when someone sees an angel or experiences the presence of God ([Judges 6:22–23](#); [13:22](#); [Isaiah 6:5](#)). The person is often reassured by a saying such as “Do not be afraid.”
- *you are to give him the name John*: In Hebrew, the name *John* means “the Lord has shown favor.” This favor came to Elizabeth and Zechariah through their son and to the Israelite nation through the Christ (Messiah), whose coming John would announce.

Luke 1:15

- *He shall never take wine or strong drink:* In the Old Testament, avoiding alcohol was part of the Nazirite vow (a special commitment to God; see [Numbers 6:1–21](#)). This commitment or promise to God was usually temporary (see [Acts 18:18; 21:23, 26](#)).

It was a commitment for life for some people, such as:

- Samson ([Judges 13:4–7](#)),
- Samuel (compare [1 Samuel 1:11](#)), and
- John the Baptist.
- *filled with the Holy Spirit even from his mother's womb:* See [Luke 1:41, 44](#).

Luke 1:17

he will go on before the Lord in the spirit and power of Elijah: The prophet Malachi prophesied that God would send Elijah before the time of God's salvation (see [Malachi 3:1; 4:5–6](#)). John the Baptist filled this role by preparing the way for the Lord's coming.

Luke 1:19

I am Gabriel: The Bible names two angels:

- *Gabriel* ([Daniel 8:16; 9:21](#))
- *Michael* ([Daniel 10:13; 12:1; Jude 1:9; Revelation 12:7](#))

Luke 1:20

- *now you will be silent and unable to speak:* God's discipline for Zechariah's lack of faith also confirmed the prophecy. The Greek word translated as "unable to speak" in [1:22](#) can also mean "deaf" ([7:22](#); compare [1:62](#)).
- Zechariah is contrasted with Mary, the mother of Jesus, who responded with faith ([1:38](#)).

Luke 1:24

for five months remained in seclusion: Why she did this is uncertain and does not seem related to any Old Testament custom or command. Perhaps it was an act of spiritual commitment to honor God for answered prayer.

Luke 1:26

Nazareth was a small village in Galilee, southwest of the Sea of Galilee. People did not think highly of it (see [John 1:46](#)).

Luke 1:27

- *pledged in marriage:* In Jewish culture, families arranged marriages, and pledging someone in marriage was a formal legal contract. Girls were usually married by their mid-teens.

- *Joseph, who was of the house of David:* See [Matthew 1:1–16](#). Joseph's ancestry is important because the Christ (Messiah) was to be a descendant of King David ([2 Samuel 7:11–16; Isaiah 9:7](#)).

Luke 1:31

you are to give Him the name Jesus: The name *Jesus* means "the Lord saves."

Luke 1:32–33

These verses echo God's covenant with David (a binding promise God made with King David; [2 Samuel 7:11–16](#)). This promise became the foundation for the hope of a coming Messiah (the Christ, God's chosen king and savior; see also [Isaiah 9:6–7; 11:1–5; Jeremiah 23:5–6; 33:15–16; Ezekiel 37:24–25](#)).

Luke 1:35

The Holy Spirit will come upon you: The conception of Jesus (how he began to grow in Mary's womb) was a miracle, by *the power of the Most High* (a title for God). The text does not explain how this happened.

Luke 1:36

Elizabeth your relative: The King James Version calls Elizabeth Mary's cousin, but the Greek word is less specific. It refers more generally to a female relative, so the exact family relationship is not known.

Luke 1:39

The hill country of Judah was (129 to 161 kilometers (80 to 100 miles) from Nazareth. This journey would take at least four days to travel on foot.

Luke 1:41

- *The baby leaped in her womb* (see [1:15](#)): John was already announcing the Messiah's coming.
- *Elizabeth was filled with the Holy Spirit:* In the Old Testament, being filled with the Spirit was often associated with a prophetic gift. The Spirit of prophecy was again appearing in Israel (see [1:67; 2:25, 27](#)).

Luke 1:46–55

Mary's song is the first of three songs of praise in the birth story of Jesus. It is called the *Magnificat* (Latin for "magnifies"). The song has many similarities to Hannah's prayer in [1 Samuel 2:1–10](#).

The fact that God cares for the oppressed and reverses their fortunes is a common theme throughout Luke's Gospel. The coming of God's kingdom brings salvation to rejected and outcast people.

Luke 1:48

all generations will call me blessed: In Middle Eastern culture, honor and shame were very important. People also deeply valued the family name they would leave to future generations.

Luke 1:51

His arm represents God's great power (see [Psalm 98:1](#); [Isaiah 40:10](#)).

Luke 1:54–55

- Gabriel's words in [1:32–33](#) refer back to God's promise to King David. Here, Mary refers to God's promise to Abraham ([Genesis 12:1–3](#); [17:3–8](#)).
- The arrival of Jesus brought glory to Israel and salvation to Gentiles (see [Luke 2:32](#)).

Luke 1:59

- God commanded every Israelite to circumcise their boys when eight days old ([Genesis 17:9–14](#); [Leviticus 12:3](#)). Circumcision marked the child's entry into Israel's covenant community.
- *they were going to name him after his father Zechariah:* Naming a child after a relative was common. The family and friends were surprised because John was not the name of any of his relatives.

Luke 1:62–63

they made signs: This was because Zechariah was not able to speak or hear (see study note on [1:20](#)). Zechariah showed his faith and obedience to God by naming the child John. As a result, God restored his voice and hearing.

Luke 1:66

the Lord's hand: This *anthropomorphism* (describing God with human characteristics, compare [1:51](#)) meant that God was at work in John's life.

Luke 1:67–79

This second song of praise in the birth story of Jesus is called the *Benedictus* (Latin for "Blessed" or "Praise"). The song expects that God's Messiah (his chosen leader) will save the Israelites from their enemies. Salvation includes physical rescue and forgiveness of sins ([1:77](#)).

Luke 1:68

He has visited and redeemed His people: This recalls the exodus from Egypt, when God rescued his people from Pharaoh ([Exodus 3:7–10](#), [17–20](#)).

Luke 1:69

- *He has raised up a horn of salvation:* A *horn of salvation* refers to the horn of a strong animal like a ram or an ox. To *raise up a horn* means to show strength and power (see also [Psalms 89:24](#); [132:17](#)).
- *in the house of His servant David:* See study note on [Luke 1:32–33](#).

Luke 1:71

salvation from our enemies: This refers to what many people in Israel hoped for. They expected God to rescue them from their physical enemies, especially the Romans. But Jesus came to bring a deeper salvation. He saves people from sin, from Satan, and from death.

Luke 1:76–77

- *And you, child:* Zechariah turned from speaking about the coming Messiah to address his newborn son, John, who would prepare the Messiah's way.
- *called a prophet of the Most High:* John was the last and greatest in the line of Old Testament prophets (see [7:28](#)).
- *prepare the way for Him:* See [Isaiah 40:3](#).

Luke 1:78

the Dawn will visit us from on high: The Old Testament identifies the Messiah (Christ) as a light shining in darkness ([Isaiah 9:2](#); [42:6–7](#); [49:6](#); [Malachi 4:2](#)).

Luke 1:80

- *the child grew and became strong in spirit:* Compare [2:40](#), [52](#); [1 Samuel 2:21](#), [26](#); [3:19](#).
- John likely lived in the wilderness west of the Jordan River and southeast of Jerusalem. This area was a place of spiritual testing ([Deuteronomy 8:2](#); [Psalms 78](#), [95](#), [107](#)). It was also a place for spiritual retreat and preparation ([Exodus 3](#); [1 Kings 19:4–6](#), [11–18](#); [Isaiah 40:3](#)).

Luke 2:1

- Caesar Augustus was also called Octavian. He ruled the Roman Empire from 27 BC to AD 14. Before his rule, Rome was a republic governed by the Senate. The Senate gave Augustus supreme power, and Rome became an empire. Augustus protected the empire's borders and began the Pax Romana ("Roman Peace"). This was a long period of peace and success around the Mediterranean Sea.
- A census was an official count of the people. Rome used a census to register people for taxes.

Luke 2:1–7

After describing the birth of John, Luke gives a similar account of the birth of Jesus. Luke emphasizes the lowliness

(very humble condition) of the birth of Jesus. Although Jesus was the Messiah (God's chosen king and deliverer), he entered the world in humble circumstances.

Luke 2:2

Quirinius was governor of Syria: He held this position from AD 6 to AD 9. Earlier, from 6 to 4 BC, he also had authority in Judea, perhaps through a form of joint rule. He may have begun the census (an official count of people for taxes).

Historical records mention three other censuses at that time in Syria, Gaul, and Spain. It would not be unusual to have one in Judea, even though no non-biblical record mentions it.

Jesus was born around 6 to 4 BC, before the death of Herod the Great in 4 BC (see [Matthew 2:1–19](#)).

Luke 2:3–4

Since Joseph was a descendant of King David, he returned to David's hometown of Bethlehem ([1 Samuel 17:12, 58; 20:6](#)). Bethlehem is a small village in Judea, eight kilometers (five miles) south of Jerusalem. The prophet Micah foretold that the Christ (the Messiah, God's chosen king) would be born there ([Micah 5:2](#)).

Luke 2:5

Mary, who was pledged to him in marriage: See study note on 1:27.

Luke 2:7

- *wrapped Him in swaddling cloths:* This was a common way to show motherly love and care (see [Ezekiel 16:4](#)).
- *a manger:* This was a feeding container for animals.
- *there was no room for them in the inn:* The word translated as *inn* does not refer to a commercial inn (a place where travelers pay to stay). Such inns were likely not found in a small town like Bethlehem. It more likely refers to a guest room in a private home or a simple shelter for travelers. Since there was no usual place to stay, Joseph and Mary went to an area where animals were kept.

Luke 2:8

- Shepherds were sometimes described in Judaism as wandering people and even as dishonest troublemakers. However, this view was not the same everywhere. In the Old Testament, shepherds are often seen in a positive way (for example, [Psalm 23:1](#)). Jesus came to people like these, who were ordinary, poor, and humble.
- *residing in the fields:* This detail suggests a warmer time of year, perhaps from March to November, although some shepherds stayed outside all year. We do not know the exact month Jesus was born.

- They guarded their flocks against thieves and wild animals.

Luke 2:9–10

- *terrified:* Like Zechariah and Mary, the angel's presence was both glorious and frightening. The angel told the shepherds, "*Do not be afraid!*" (compare [1:11–13, 28–30](#)).
- *I bring you good news:* This Greek verb (*euangelizō*, meaning "to bring good news") comes from the same root as the word *euangelion* ("good news" or "gospel"). In the Berean Standard Bible, *euangelion* is often translated as "gospel" (for example, [Galatians 2:5, 7, 14](#)). Isaiah's prophecies describe God's salvation as "good tidings" or "good news" (see, for example, [Isaiah 52:7; 61:1](#)).
- *for all the people:* In Luke's writings, *the people* (a singular term in Greek) always refers to the people of Israel. The shepherds were told that Israel's salvation had arrived. It would eventually go to all nations.

Luke 2:11

The word "Messiah" means "Anointed One." It comes from the Hebrew word *mashiakh* and is translated into Greek as *Christos*. The Messiah refers to the promised savior who would come from King David's family line (see study note on 1:32–33). As the apostles started preaching the good news about Jesus to the non-Jewish world, Christians started using *Christos* more as a name than a title.

Luke 2:12

a sign: Shepherds would notice the contrast between the baby's security and his lowly circumstances. He was wrapped in strips of cloth, but he was lying in a manger, an animal feeding box. This was unusual and showed that God was at work.

Luke 2:13

the heavenly host: These armies from heaven show God's ultimate power and authority ([2 Kings 6:17; Psalm 148:2](#)). *LORD of Hosts* is a common Old Testament name for God (for example, [1 Samuel 1:11; 17:45; 2 Samuel 7:8; Isaiah 5:16; Romans 9:29; James 5:4](#)).

Luke 2:14

- *Glory to God in the highest:* This short hymn is known as the *Gloria in excelsis Deo* from the Latin translation of the first line. The Messiah's coming brings glory to God in the heavens and peace to humans on earth.
- *peace to men on whom His favor rests:* *Peace* means "complete well-being," not just the absence of hostility. The traditional translation, "on earth peace, good will toward men" in the King James Version, is based on the reading of some late manuscripts. The Berean Standard Bible text

follows other early versions. Peace comes to those who receive God's grace.

Luke 2:19

Mary treasured up all these things and pondered them in her heart: Mary kept these things in her heart. This may mean she thought deeply about what had happened and wondered what the future of Jesus would be. It may also mean that Luke learned about these events from Mary herself.

Luke 2:20

glorifying and praising God: These are major themes throughout Luke's Gospel (for example, [1:64](#); [2:13](#), [28](#); [5:25–26](#); [7:16](#); [13:13](#); [17:15](#), [18](#); [18:43](#); [19:37](#); [23:47](#); [24:53](#)).

Luke 2:21

eight days before His circumcision had passed: See study note on [1:59](#).

Luke 2:22

- *the time of purification:* The law of Moses required women to complete a 40-day ceremony of purification after giving birth ([Leviticus 12](#)). After this period, they would offer the sacrifice commanded by the law ([Luke 2:24](#)).
- *to present Him to the Lord:* Every person or thing born first belonged to the Lord, so the Israelites would *present* (or consecrate) them to God. Humans were bought back with a redemption price (see [Exodus 13:1–2](#), [15](#); [34:19–20](#); [Numbers 3:11–13](#); [18:15–16](#); [Nehemiah 10:35–36](#)).

Luke 2:24

A pair of turtledoves or two young pigeons: This quote from [Leviticus 12:8](#) refers to the ceremony to make a woman ceremonially pure after giving birth to a child. Joseph and Mary offered the sacrifice prescribed for the poor.

Luke 2:25

- *Simeon ... was righteous and devout:* This is like Zechariah and Elizabeth ([1:6](#)). They represent the faithful people of Israel who were waiting for God's salvation ([Isaiah 10:20–22](#)). Some think Simeon was a priest, but the text only says he was a *devout* man in Jerusalem.
- *He was waiting for the consolation of Israel:* This refers to [Isaiah 40:1](#), which promised "comfort" to Israel after returning from exile in Babylon.
- *the Holy Spirit was upon him:* See study note on [Luke 1:41](#).

Luke 2:26

the Lord's Christ (or the Lord's Anointed): This title was first used for kings like David. It later came to refer to the Christ

or Messiah (God's chosen king and deliverer), who would come from David's family line.

Luke 2:27

into the temple courts: This refers to the temple complex, not the sanctuary. See study note on [1:8–9](#).

Luke 2:29–32

This third great hymn of the birth narrative is called the *Nunc dimittis* ("now dismiss"), from the first words of the Latin translation. The hymn praises God for allowing Simeon to see God's salvation.

Luke 2:30

my eyes have seen Your salvation: This phrase echoes [Isaiah 52:12](#). The wording is similar and recalls the language of that passage.

Luke 2:31

The plural form of *people* means all peoples (see study note on [2:9–10](#)). It includes both Jews and Gentiles. Gentiles are people who are not part of the Jewish people.

Luke 2:32

- The prophet Isaiah predicted that the kingdom of God would bring salvation to all the nations ([Isaiah 42:6–7](#); [49:6](#)).
- *the glory of your people Israel:* This quote from [Isaiah 46:13](#) says that God's salvation will bring glory to Israel. Israel's role in the Old Testament was to bring glory to God by revealing God's light to the nations.

Luke 2:34

- *to cause the rise and fall of many in Israel:* Many Israelites did not accept Jesus as the Christ (see [Isaiah 8:14–15](#)).
- *a sign:* See [Luke 11:29–30](#); compare [Isaiah 8:18](#).

Luke 2:35

- *The thoughts of many hearts:* Israel's true inner response to God would be made known through how they respond to Jesus.
- *a sword will pierce your soul as well:* Mary would experience great pain watching her son suffer and die on the cross.

Luke 2:36–38

- Anna is the Greek version of the Hebrew name Hannah, Samuel's mother ([1 Samuel 1–2](#)). Jewish tradition recognizes seven Old Testament women as prophets:
- Sarah,
- Miriam,

- Deborah,
- Hannah,
- Abigail,
- Huldah, and
- Esther.

In this story, Anna was also a prophetic witness to the identity of Jesus as the Christ.

- *the tribe of Asher*: This was one of the 10 northern tribes of Israel. Asher was the eighth son of the patriarch Jacob ([Genesis 30:12–13](#)). Most of the Israelites who returned from exile in Babylon were from the tribe of Judah. Other Israelites also knew the family line of their tribe during the time of Jesus. For example, the apostle Paul was “of the tribe of Benjamin” ([Philippians 3:5](#)).

Luke 2:37

- *was a widow to the age of eighty-four*: In the ancient world, people associated old age with wisdom and honor.
- *She never left the temple*: This is likely an intentional extreme statement (an exaggeration). It is the same as saying something like, “She was there all the time.” This statement shows her total commitment to God.

Luke 2:40

He was filled with wisdom, and the grace of God was upon Him (compare [1:80](#); [2:52](#)): The two statements about the wisdom of Jesus ([2:40](#), [52](#)) emphasize the story of his unusual wisdom at a young age.

Luke 2:41

The Jewish Passover feast celebrates God’s deliverance of Israel from slavery in Egypt. It was one of three major annual feasts required for Jewish men to attend ([Exodus 23:14–17](#); [Deuteronomy 16:16](#)). The family of Jesus faithfully followed God’s law and practiced their faith.

Luke 2:41–51

Jesus visiting Jerusalem at age 12 is the only story from his childhood in the gospels. The main theme is his early spiritual insight. This includes how he is increasingly aware of his special relationship with God and his unique mission.

Luke 2:42

He was twelve years old: A Jewish boy took on his covenant responsibilities (duties in God’s agreement with his people) at about age 13. The *bar mitzvah* (a later ceremony marking this stage) developed afterward to express this custom.

By bringing Jesus to Jerusalem at this time, his parents were preparing him to take his place in the covenant community.

Luke 2:44

Assuming He was in their company: Joseph and Mary were probably traveling with a large caravan of relatives and friends from Galilee. Jesus probably spent a lot of time with his friends and relatives, so his parents were not worried at first.

Luke 2:46

The *three days* likely included one day traveling from Jerusalem, one day traveling back, and one day searching.

- *in the temple courts*: He was in the temple complex, not the sanctuary.
- *listening to them and asking them questions*: Jesus was acting like a student. In rabbinic teaching (the teaching methods of Jewish teachers), a teacher often answered a student’s question by asking more questions. Jesus asked wise questions and gave wise answers, and this amazed the teachers.

Luke 2:47

astounded at His understanding and His answers: Jesus fulfilled [Isaiah 11:2](#).

Luke 2:49

Did you not know that I had to be in My Father’s house?: Jesus knew his most important relationship was with his Father in heaven.

Luke 2:51

Although Jesus recognized his relationship to his heavenly Father, he was obedient to his earthly parents.

Luke 3:1

- *In the fifteenth year of the reign of Tiberius Caesar*: Tiberius Caesar began to rule with his stepfather, Caesar Augustus, in AD 11. He became the sole emperor in AD 14 and ruled until AD 37. Luke may be counting from either AD 11 or AD 14. If so, John began his public ministry around AD 26/27 or AD 29/30. Jesus began his own ministry soon after John.
- Pontius Pilate was governor of Judea from AD 26 to 36 (see “Pontius Pilate” Profile).
- *Herod tetrarch of Galilee*: See “Herod Antipas” Profile.
- Antipas’s half-brother Philip was another son of Herod the Great. Philip ruled as tetrarch of the region northeast of Galilee from 4 BC until his death in AD 34. *Tetrarch* means “the ruler of a fourth of a kingdom.” The term later meant any minor ruler. Philip was a half brother of both Antipas and Herod Philip ([Matthew 14:3](#); [Mark 6:17](#)).

Luke 3:1–4.13

After the birth story, Luke prepares his audience for the public ministry of Jesus. He describes the work of John the Baptist, who comes before the Messiah (the Christ, God's chosen king). He also tells about the baptism, family line (genealogy), and temptation of Jesus.

Luke 3:2

- **Annas and Caiaphas** were Jewish high priests. Annas served from AD 6 to 15 until the Romans removed him. His son-in-law, Caiaphas, was the high priest from AD 18 to 36. Luke mentions both names because Annas was still very influential among the Jews (see [John 18:13–14, 24](#); [Acts 4:6](#)).
- *the word of God came to John son of Zechariah*: John's role as a prophet was similar to that of the Old Testament prophets (see, for example, [Isaiah 6](#); [Jeremiah 1](#)).

Luke 3:3

preaching a baptism of repentance for the forgiveness of sins: John seems to have adapted the practice of baptism from Jewish rites using water to cleanse, or set apart, people and objects for God's service (compare [Leviticus 8:6](#)). John called people to repent of their sins and prepare spiritually for the Messiah's coming. Their baptism publicly demonstrated their repentance and spiritual cleansing.

Luke 3:4–6

- The quotation is from the ancient Greek version of [Isaiah 40:3–5](#). It describes God bringing the Jews back from exile in Babylon. After they returned ([Ezra 1–2](#)), John shouted in the wilderness to prepare God's people for the Lord's coming. God's salvation is portrayed as a new exodus, bringing deliverance like the first exodus from Egypt.
- *make straight paths for Him ... the rough ways smooth*: This image reflects the Middle Eastern custom of preparing a road for a king (compare [Luke 19:36–38](#)).

Luke 3:7

God's *coming wrath* is the judgment for all who reject the gospel. Israel as a nation would experience this wrath in the destruction of Jerusalem in AD 70 (see [21:20–23](#)).

Luke 3:8

- *We have Abraham as our father*: Some Jews believed that being part of Abraham's family line guaranteed their salvation (see [John 8:33–39](#); [Acts 7:2](#); [Romans 4:1](#)).
- *And do not begin to say to yourselves, 'We have Abraham as our father'*: God chose the Israelites as his people, but he could reject them. If he wanted, he could create children of

Abraham from these very stones (compare [Hosea 1:3–9](#); [Romans 9:6–8, 27–28](#); [11:17–21](#)).

Luke 3:9

every tree that does not produce good fruit: If Israel did not repent and produce good works, God would judge them to be as worthless as a vineyard without grapes (see [Isaiah 5:1–7](#); compare [Luke 13:7–9](#); [20:9–19](#)).

Luke 3:11

two tunics: The Greek word refers to a long shirt worn next to the skin. Even the smallest surplus should be shared with others in need.

Luke 3:12

even tax collectors: In the first century, many people strongly disliked tax collectors. They were known for taking extra money and were seen as working for the Roman rulers, who were widely hated.

Luke 3:14

These soldiers were probably not Roman, but local Jewish troops under the authority of Herod Antipas. They might have been assigned to protect the tax collectors. John does not condemn either tax collectors or soldiers but calls them to honesty and integrity.

Luke 3:16

- *the straps of whose sandals I am not worthy to untie*: The untying of sandals was done only by slaves. John was showing great honor to Jesus the Messiah.
- *Baptize you with the Holy Spirit and fire*: Old Testament prophets said God would give his Spirit to his people in the last times ([Isaiah 32:15](#), [Ezekiel 36:28–29](#); [Joel 2:28](#)). This prophecy partly came true on the day of Pentecost ([Acts 2](#)). Fire often represents judgment (see [Luke 3:9](#)). It can also represent the spiritual cleansing and purifying of God's people (see [1 Corinthians 3:10–15](#); compare [Isaiah 4:4](#); [Malachi 3:2](#)).

Luke 3:17

- After being harvested, the kernels of wheat would be beaten off the stalks and then tossed in the air with a winnowing fork to separate them from the chaff. The heavy grain would fall to the ground as the lighter chaff blew away. This is an image of separation for judgment.
- *unquenchable fire*: See [Isaiah 66:24](#).

Luke 3:19–20

Herod Antipas was the ruler of Galilee. *He* divorced his first wife and married Herodias. Herodias was the wife of his half-brother Herod Philip.

When John publicly criticized Herod for this sin, Herod imprisoned and later executed him (compare 9:9; [Mark 6:16–29](#)). Herod's execution of John is also recorded by the Jewish historian Josephus (*Antiquities* 18.5.2).

Luke 3:21

- *And as He was praying*: Luke shows that Jesus trusted God and depended on him through prayer ([5:16](#); [6:12](#); [9:18](#), [28](#); [11:1](#); [22:32](#), [41](#), [44](#); [23:34](#), [46](#)).
- *heaven was opened*: This image was a sign of
- God's presence ([Isaiah 64:1](#)),
- divine revelation ([Ezekiel 1:1](#); [John 1:51](#)), and
- the end of an age (a major period in God's plan; [Revelation 4:1](#); [15:5](#); [19:11](#)).

Luke 3:21–22

The baptism of Jesus marked the beginning of his public ministry and his anointing as the Christ (the Messiah, the one chosen and set apart by God). God spoke from heaven and confirmed who Jesus is and the mission he came to do.

Luke 3:22

- The Holy Spirit might have looked like a dove, or it might have come down as a dove would.
- *You are My beloved Son; in You I am well pleased*: This statement connects with [Psalm 2:7](#) and [Isaiah 42:1](#).
- [Psalm 2:7](#) shows that Jesus is the Messiah (the Christ, the promised King) from David's family line.
- [Isaiah 42:1](#) shows the servant of the Lord (the one chosen to carry out God's work).

God again declared who Jesus is from heaven at his transfiguration (when his appearance was changed in glory; [Luke 9:35](#)).

Luke 3:23

Jesus was about thirty years old: This is the only reference in the New Testament to Jesus' age during his public ministry, and it is an approximation. Jesus was born 6–4 BC (see study note on 2:2) and began his ministry AD 27–29 (see study note on 3:1), so Jesus was evidently 31–35 years old when he began his public ministry. • known as the son of Joseph: Jesus was the legal but not the biological son of Joseph. • Joseph was the son of Heli: If this is actually Mary's genealogy (see study note on 3:23–38), then Joseph was Heli's son-in-law, a possible understanding of the Greek sentence.

Luke 3:23–38

This genealogy reverses Matthew's order ([Matt 1:1–17](#)). Luke lists Jesus' lineage back to Adam, possibly to show Jesus' connection with all humanity as the Son of God ([Luke 3:38](#)). Matthew's genealogy descends from Abraham to Joseph, highlighting Jesus' status as the rightful heir of David's throne and the recipient of God's promises to Abraham. The great differences between the two genealogies have led some to propose that Luke's genealogy is that of Mary (see study note on 3:23), who was probably among Luke's primary sources.

Luke 3:27

Zerubbabel was the governor of Judea. The Persians chose him when the Jews returned from exile in Babylon. He supervised the effort to build the temple again ([Ezra 3:2](#), [8](#)).

Luke 3:31

Nathan was King David's third son, born in Jerusalem ([2 Samuel 5:14](#)). This is not the same person as Nathan the prophet ([2 Samuel 7:2](#)).

Luke 3:32

Boaz married Ruth, who was from Moab (see [Ruth 2–4](#)).

Luke 3:38

Seth was the third son of Adam and Eve, born after Cain murdered Abel and God banished him ([Gen 4:25–26](#)).

- Adam was the son of God: Adam had no earthly father since God created him. In the temptation that follows, Satan repeatedly says to Jesus, "If you are the Son of God. . . ." Adam, the first son of God, failed when tested, but Jesus, the Son of God in the fullest sense, successfully resisted temptation.

Luke 4:1–13

Satan tempted Jesus to bypass his Father's plan of salvation by taking power and glory for himself. The forty-day temptation in the wilderness parallels Israel's forty years of testing in the wilderness. Israel failed when tested, but Jesus was victorious.

Luke 4:2

tempted by the devil: The term *diabolos* is a Greek translation of the Hebrew *satan*, meaning "accuser" or "adversary" ([1 Chr 21:1](#); [Job 1:1–2:13](#); [Zech 3:1–2](#)). Luke uses both terms ("devil," [Luke 4:3](#), [6](#), [13](#); [8:12](#); "Satan," [10:18](#); [11:18](#); [13:16](#); [22:3](#), [31](#)). Adam and Eve were tested by Satan and failed; Jesus, the second Adam, resisted temptation and thus reversed the judgment against Adam and Eve.

Luke 4:3

If you are the Son of God: Both Israel and Adam are identified as God's son (3:38; [Exod 4:22–23](#); [Hos 11:1](#)). Jesus, the Son of God in the fullest sense, succeeded where Adam and Israel failed.

Luke 4:4

Man shall not live on bread alone: Israel complained constantly about hunger in the wilderness, but Jesus depended on God's strength to sustain him.

Luke 4:6

I can give it to anyone I wish: The New Testament elsewhere describes Satan's limited rule over the present world order ([John 12:31](#); [14:30](#); [16:11](#); [Ephesians 2:2](#); [1 John 5:19](#)).

Luke 4:8

Worship the Lord your God and serve Him only: When Israel encountered difficulties in the wilderness, they started to worship false gods ([Deuteronomy 9:12](#)). Jesus refused to worship Satan.

Luke 4:10–11

After being driven back twice by Scripture, the devil quoted Scripture to Jesus. He cited a passage that speaks of God's protection for his people.

Luke 4:12

Do not put the Lord your God to the test: In the wilderness, Israel constantly tested God's faithfulness, but Jesus responded with complete trust in God.

Luke 4:13

The next *opportune time* could have been when Judas betrayed Jesus ([22:3–6](#), [21–22](#), [47–48](#)). The greatest test occurred in the garden of Gethsemane ([22:39–46](#)).

Luke 4:14

- *Jesus returned to Galilee:* The story of the ministry of Jesus in Galilee begins here, and continues through [9:50](#).
- *in the power of the Spirit:* At his baptism, Jesus was anointed and empowered to accomplish his role as the Messiah (see [3:22](#); [4:1](#), [14](#), [18](#)).

Luke 4:16–30

The sermon Jesus gave in Nazareth showed what his whole public ministry would be about. He returned to the synagogue in his hometown to announce the good news that God's salvation had come. The people were pleased at first. But then Jesus reminded them that God also reaches out to

Gentiles, not only to Jews. This made the crowd so angry that they tried to kill him.

Luke 4:18–19

The time of the Lord's favor refers to the Year of Jubilee ([Lev 25:8–55](#)), when debts were erased, slaves were freed, and land was returned to its original owners. In [Isa 61](#), the Year of Jubilee is a metaphor for God's salvation.

Luke 4:21

- *is fulfilled:* Jesus announced that his presence marked the new age of salvation (God's saving work among his people).
- *Today:* Compare [2:11](#); [5:26](#); [19:9](#); [23:43](#).

Luke 4:23

Physician, heal yourself was a common proverb in the ancient world. Here it might mean "prove your healing powers," or "help your own people, not just others." • like those you did in Capernaum: See [4:31–44](#).

Luke 4:25–26

widow of Zarephath: See [1 Kings 17–18](#).

Luke 4:27

Naaman the Syrian: See [2 Kings 5](#).

Luke 4:28

The people in the synagogue were furious that Jesus pointed out the favor God had shown to Gentiles. The Jews viewed themselves as sole recipients of God's favor, and they were oppressed by Gentile overlords.

Luke 4:30

he passed right through the crowd: The main emphasis is on the sovereign majesty of Jesus. His time had not yet come (cp. [John 7:30](#), [44](#); [8:20](#), [59](#)). This attempt to kill Jesus anticipated his crucifixion, so his escape foreshadows his resurrection.

Luke 4:31

Jesus left Nazareth and made Capernaum his main base during his work in Galilee (see [Mark 2:1](#)).

Luke 4:33

the spirit of an unclean demon: Here *unclean* means "defiled" or "wicked."

Luke 4:34

- *Have you come to destroy us?*: Although there was only one demon present, the use of *us* suggests that all of Satan's forces knew about and were fearful of the coming of Jesus.
- *I know who You are*: In ancient times, people believed that naming a spiritual power gave them control over it. The demon might have been trying to gain power over Jesus.

Luke 4:36

With authority and power He commands: Magicians and exorcists often used long rituals and special spoken formulas (incantations). The people were amazed that Jesus simply spoke a word with his own authority and drove out the demon.

Luke 4:38

Simon's home: Simon was from Bethsaida ([John 1:44](#)), but his present home and fishing business were in Capernaum.

- Simon's mother-in-law: Peter was married (see [1 Cor 9:5](#)), but his wife is not named.

Luke 4:39

rebuked the fever: Luke uses the same Greek word when Jesus "rebuked the demon" ([4:35](#)). Jesus has full authority over both physical and spiritual powers.

Luke 4:41

- *You are the Son of God!*: This was a title used for the Christ (God's chosen king and deliverer, the Messiah; see [2 Samuel 7:14](#); [Psalms 2:7](#); [89:26–27](#)). Luke often connects the titles *Christ* and *the Son of God* ([Luke 9:35](#); [22:66–71](#); [Acts 9:20](#), [22](#)).
- would not allow them to speak: Jesus often showed his authority over demons by making them silent. He wanted to reveal his identity in his own way, not through their announcement.

Luke 4:43

The Greek verb translated *preach* the Good News corresponds to the noun often translated "gospel" ("Good News"; see study note on [2:9–10](#); see also [1:19](#); [7:22](#); [Matt 4:23](#); [24:14](#); [Mark 1:1](#), [15](#); [16:15](#); [Acts 8:4](#), [12](#); [Rom 1:1–6](#), [15–17](#); [10:15–17](#); [Gal 1:6–9](#); [Eph 2:14–18](#); [3:6–7](#)). • The Kingdom of God was Jesus' central concern (see [Mark 1:15](#)), and God's sovereign reign was established through Jesus' words and deeds.

Luke 4:44

Luke likely used the word *Judea* in a broad sense, meaning "the land of the Jews." At that time, Jesus was ministering in Galilee in the north (see [5:1](#)), not in Judea in the south.

Luke 5:1–11

This is the first time Luke records Jesus calling the disciples to follow him. Matthew and Mark describe an earlier calling of the four brothers who were fishermen ([Matthew 4:18–22](#); [Mark 1:16–20](#)). Jesus showed great authority in the miraculous catch of fish and in his call of Simon Peter.

Luke 5:3

And sitting down, He taught the people from the boat: By sitting a little away from the shore, Jesus had a place to speak without the people pressing against him.

Luke 5:4

let down your nets to catch some fish: Peter was naturally skeptical when a rabbi told fishermen how to catch fish. Jesus' command was odd for three reasons: (1) When the sun came up, the fish moved to the bottom of the lake (which is why they fished at night); (2) they fished with a heavy dragnet hung over the side of the boat by two men (or between two boats) and could not go deep with it; (3) they had just fished all night with no results, and the prospects were now much more unlikely.

Luke 5:7

Their partners in the other boat were James and John, who with their father Zebedee were business partners with Peter (see [5:10](#); [Mark 1:19–20](#)) and Andrew (see [Mark 1:16](#)). • both boats were filled with fish: This dramatic miracle confirmed Jesus' authority over the forces of nature.

Luke 5:8

I am a sinful man: Compare [Isaiah 6:5](#).

Luke 5:10

Jesus used fishing as a picture to explain how his followers would gather people into the kingdom of God.

Luke 5:11

they left everything: They gave up their work, security, and family ties, which was remarkable in a culture that placed great importance on loyalty to family and clan.

Luke 5:12

an advanced case of leprosy: "Leprosy" does not refer specifically to the modern disease known as leprosy (Hansen's disease), but to a variety of skin disorders. To avoid contagion, lepers were outcasts in the ancient world, required to live on the margins of society. The law of Moses set guidelines for the diagnosis and quarantine of leprosy ([Lev 13–14](#)).

Luke 5:13

Jesus reached out and touched him: Most people feared catching the disease through physical contact, but Jesus showed compassion. Jesus was not contaminated by disease or evil, but brought healing and salvation. • Be healed: Literally *Be cleansed*. This act had spiritual and physical significance, since leprosy separated Israelites from social contact and religious practice.

Luke 5:14

Jesus often told those he healed not to tell anyone what had happened to avoid celebrity status. Nonetheless, news of these events spreads like wildfire (see 5:15–16; see also “The Secret of the Messiah” Theme Note). • Go to the priest and let him examine you. . . . the offering: Those healed of leprosy had to be declared clean by a priest, and a sacrifice was offered on their behalf.

Luke 5:17

Pharisees: See “The Pharisees” Profile. • Teachers of religious law, also called “scribes” and “lawyers,” were experts in interpreting the law of Moses. Most of the scribes were Pharisees, though some were Sadducees.

Luke 5:17–26

The healing of the paralyzed man began the conflicts between Jesus and the religious leaders that continued through his public ministry until his crucifixion in Jerusalem.

Luke 5:19

took off some tiles: Palestinian roofs were normally made of wooden beams covered with reeds and mud or clay. Either this roof had tiles, or else Luke was interpreting the episode for his Greek readers (cp. [Mark 2:4](#), which speaks of *digging through* the roof).

Luke 5:22

Knowing what they were thinking: While the Pharisees accused Jesus of blasphemy (showing disrespect toward God), he knew what was in their minds. This is something only God can do.

Luke 5:23–24

Jesus showed his authority to forgive sins by healing the man.

Luke 5:24

Son of Man: See “The Son of Man” Theme Note.

Luke 5:27

tax collector: See study note on 3:12. • Levi’s tax collector’s booth was probably a toll booth for goods in transit. • Levi was also called Matthew ([Matt 9:9](#); see “Matthew (Levi)” Profile).

Luke 5:27–32

When Jesus called Levi to become his disciple, this led to a second conflict with the religious leaders. It also introduced the idea that Jesus came to save sinners.

Luke 5:29

a great banquet for Jesus: Levi introduced Jesus to his friends and fellow tax collectors to thank him for making Levi a disciple. It was common in the ancient world to repay honor with honor.

Luke 5:30

Meals were rituals of social status in the ancient world, and eating with someone meant social acceptance of that person. The Pharisees refused to eat with tax collectors and other sinners, or to enter their homes, believing that this would defile them. They expected Jesus, as a rabbi, to do the same. Jesus shattered social norms by dining with sinners and allowing sinful people to touch him (5:29; 7:39; 15:1). The religious leaders severely criticized him for this and derisively called him “a friend of tax collectors and other sinners” (7:34).

Luke 5:31–32

Jesus responded that, like a doctor, his mission was to work with sick people, not the healthy. Jesus was not called to minister to self-righteous people, but to those who recognized their spiritual need for God’s grace and healing.

Luke 5:33

John the Baptist’s disciples: Most rabbis had students who learned from them and served them (see also [Acts 19:1–7](#)). • fast and pray regularly: Many pious Jews fasted two days a week ([Luke 18:12](#)). Fasting was associated with spiritual preparation ([Esth 4:16](#)) and repentance ([2 Sam 12:22](#); [Joel 1:14](#); [Jon 3:5](#)). Fasting is not a means of righteousness ([Isa 58:4–5](#); [Jer 14:12](#)) but a spiritual discipline for cultivating intimacy with God. Fasting is often linked with prayer and spiritual retreat. • Why are your disciples always eating and drinking? The point was that they did not fast regularly.

Luke 5:34–35

Do wedding guests fast? Just as it would be inappropriate for anyone to fast at a wedding celebration, it was inappropriate for people to fast while the Messiah was with them. God’s

final salvation is a great wedding feast that God prepares for his people ([Isa 25:6–8](#); [Luke 14:15–24](#)).

Luke 5:36–38

a new garment . . . new wine: New cloth shrinks when washed and so tears the old; new wine expands with fermentation and breaks brittle old wineskins. In either case, both old and new are ruined. Both illustrations make the point that the old is incompatible with the new. Jesus did not come to patch up the old covenant, but to establish a new one. The Kingdom of God brings a whole new orientation to thinking and living.

Luke 5:39

The old is better: The religious leaders were resistant to change.

Luke 6:1

His disciples began to pick the heads of grain: The law allowed this kind of grazing while walking through someone else's field ([Deuteronomy 23:24–25](#)).

Luke 6:1–11

Jesus' conflicts with the religious leaders continued with two controversies over the Sabbath. The law of Moses required Jews to rest on the Sabbath ([Exod 20:8–11](#); [Deut 5:13–14](#)), but the Pharisees had forgotten that the real reason for the Sabbath was to benefit human beings.

Luke 6:2

Why are you doing what is unlawful on the Sabbath?: They did not accuse the disciples of stealing grain, but of working on the Sabbath day. They were breaking rules established by oral tradition.

Luke 6:3

While fleeing from Saul ([1 Sam 21](#)), David . . . and his companions took refuge at the sanctuary of Nob. The priest Ahimelech gave them the consecrated Bread of the Presence that only priests were lawfully allowed to eat ([Exod 25:30](#); [Lev 24:9](#)). Jesus' point was that a technical violation of the law is superseded by the higher law of meeting human needs. There might also be a comparison between David and Jesus as God's chosen and anointed kings of Israel.

Luke 6:5

Lord, even over the Sabbath: The saying is a play on words with a double meaning. First, *son of man* often means "human being," so Jesus affirmed that the Sabbath was made to serve human beings. *Son of Man* was also a title for

the Messiah (see [Dan 7:13–14](#)). Jesus is Lord of the Sabbath because he created it.

Luke 6:6–7

watched Jesus closely: Jesus now had a reputation for placing human needs above the Sabbath commands, so the religious leaders hoped to catch him working on the Sabbath. • If he healed the man's hand: The rabbis of Jesus' day debated whether offering medical help was justified on the Sabbath; it was generally allowed only in extreme emergencies. The deformed hand was clearly not an emergency.

Luke 6:8

Get up and stand among us: Jesus did not avoid controversy. He was willing to confront the Pharisees' hypocrisy directly.

Luke 6:9

to do good or to do evil, to save life or to destroy it?: This question challenged the religious leaders' intentions. They were plotting against Jesus (an evil act) because he was going to heal someone (a good act).

Luke 6:12

He spent the night in prayer to God: See study note on 3:21. Jesus prayed before important events and decisions such as choosing the Twelve, who would carry on his ministry after him.

Luke 6:13

- *Disciples* were students and followers, while *apostles* were specially commissioned representatives.
- The number *twelve* symbolically represents the twelve tribes of Israel. The apostles represented the restored people of God.

Luke 6:14

Simon, whom He named Peter: The name *Peter* means "rock" or "stone" (see [Matthew 16:18](#)).

Luke 6:15

The diversity of Jesus' apostles is striking. • Matthew, also called Levi, was the tax collector for the Romans (see [5:27](#); [Matt 9:9](#); [10:3](#)). • Simon (who was called the zealot): *Zealot* probably meant that he had joined the Zealot movement, a group of Jews actively seeking to overthrow the Roman government.

Luke 6:16

Judas (son of James) was probably also called Thaddaeus ([Matt 10:3](#); [Mark 3:18](#)). He was a different man than Judas Iscariot or Jude the half brother of Jesus (who wrote the

New Testament book of Jude). • Judas Iscariot: *Iscariot* probably means “from Kerioth,” a village twelve miles south of Hebron.

Luke 6:17

all over Judea, Jerusalem, and the seacoast of Tyre and Sidon: Tyre and Sidon were coastal cities on the Mediterranean Sea northwest of Galilee. Jesus was gaining wide popularity.

Luke 6:17–49

The main theme of the great sermon of Jesus is that those who repent and enter the kingdom of God will live in a truly righteous way.

Luke 6:20–21

poor ... you who hunger: Compare [Matthew 5:3, 6](#). This statement likely refers to both physical and spiritual poverty. Poverty and suffering tend to make us more dependent on God. The Old Testament includes many promises that God will feed and comfort his people ([Psalms 22:26; 107:36–41; 126:1–6; Isaiah 49:10–13; 51:3; 65:13](#)).

Luke 6:20–23

God blesses those who admit their weaknesses and seek strength from God. The value system of God’s kingdom is radically different from the world’s value system, in which power and strength represent success.

Luke 6:23

treated the prophets in the same way: See “The Suffering Prophet” Theme Note.

Luke 6:24–26

Promises of blessing for the poor and oppressed are balanced in Luke with predictions of sorrow for the rich and powerful. Those who trust in themselves will be humbled, while those who depend on God will be blessed. The Old Testament prophets often pronounced woes against nations and rulers who oppressed God’s people and rejected his sovereignty (e.g., [Isa 3:11; 5:8; Jer 50:27; Zech 11:17](#)).

Luke 6:27

love your enemies! People were commonly taught in the ancient world to love their family and friends and hate their enemies. Jesus announced a radical new ethic of loving even one’s enemies and overcoming evil through self-sacrificial love for others, not through violence and hatred (cp. [Rom 12:14–21](#)).

Luke 6:30

when things are taken away from you, don’t try to get them back: Jesus’ point is that the cycle of hatred and violence that characterizes human nature can only be broken by responding with good, not evil ([Rom 12:17](#)). We win the world through self-sacrificial love. Jesus was not promoting injustice, as though believers should let criminals take advantage of the weak. God established governments to punish evildoers ([Rom 13:1–5](#)).

Luke 6:31

Do to others as you would like them to do to you: While the Golden Rule appears in some form in various religious and philosophical traditions, only in Jesus’ teaching is love for all people, including enemies, the fundamental ethic that governs all behavior.

Luke 6:34–36

The law of Moses prohibited charging interest on loans to other Israelites in order to prevent exploitation of the poor ([Exod 22:25; Lev 25:35–37; Deut 23:20](#)). Jesus further instructed his followers to lend . . . without expecting to be repaid. By doing good even to those who do evil, we act as children of the Most High and imitate our Father in heaven, who is kind to all people (cp. [Rom 5:8](#)).

Luke 6:37–42

Do not judge others: Jesus condemned hypocritical judgment that denigrated another person. Those who condemn others will be judged by that same standard. God requires his people to love others by warning them of the dangers of sin ([Gal 6:1; Heb 3:13](#)). Exhortation is an act of love; judgment is an act of pride.

Luke 6:38

pressed down, shaken together: A generous grain merchant would top off the buyer’s container, press it down, shake it to make more room, and then pour until the grain overflowed into the buyer’s lap.

Luke 6:41

a log in your own: Jesus did not say that the speck in our friend’s eye is not our business, but that we must first correct our own faults so that we can see clearly enough to remove the speck. Jesus condemned hypocritical judgment; lovingly holding one another accountable regarding sin is desirable.

Luke 6:45

What people receive and value inside themselves will shape how they live. What they keep within their thoughts and desires will come out in their actions.

Luke 6:49

he one who hears My words and does not act on them: See [Ezekiel 33:31–33](#).

Luke 7:1–10

This episode shows God’s message of salvation is for Gentiles as well as Jews.

Luke 7:2

centurion: This type of Roman officer was in charge of a group of about 100 soldiers (a *century*). A Roman legion had 60 centuries, totaling 6,000 soldiers.

Luke 7:3

Jewish elders were leaders in the Jewish community. With his tendency to abbreviate accounts, Matthew has the centurion approaching Jesus ([Matt 8:5–13](#)). Luke tells the full story in which Jewish elders, and later the centurion’s friends, act as intermediaries.

Luke 7:5

he loves the Jewish people and even built a synagogue for us: Such patronage by wealthy Gentiles was common in Jewish communities throughout the Roman Empire. It suggests that the centurion might have been a “God-fearer” like Cornelius ([Acts 10:2](#)), a Gentile who worshiped the God of Israel but had not fully converted to Judaism.

Luke 7:6

I am not worthy of such an honor: The man was probably showing sensitivity to Jewish concerns; pious Jews would not enter the home of a Gentile, since it would make them ceremonially unclean (see [Acts 10:28](#); [11:12](#)). The centurion might also have been acknowledging Jesus’ superior status.

Luke 7:8

I myself am a man under authority: The Roman army was famous for its organization and discipline. The centurion recognized authority when he saw it in the words and actions of Jesus.

Luke 7:9

I tell you, not even in Israel have I found such great faith: While many in Israel were unresponsive to the good news of salvation, some Gentiles believed and found salvation.

Luke 7:11

The location of the village of Nain is uncertain. It might be the modern town of Nein, 9.6 kilometers (6 miles) southeast of Nazareth.

Luke 7:11–17

Jesus raised three people from the dead:

- the dead man in this passage,
- Jairus’s daughter ([8:40–56](#)), and
- Lazarus ([John 11:38–44](#)).

Jesus has power over life and death (compare [1 Kings 17:17–24](#); [2 Kings 4:18–37](#)).

Luke 7:12

A funeral procession: In Judaism, a large crowd of mourners and intense wailing signified great love for the deceased. Mourners were hired in some cases. • Widows were the most vulnerable members of society, and God had special concern for them ([Exod 22:22](#); [Deut 10:18](#); [27:19](#)). This widow’s only son was her means of support and hope for the future; his death was a terrible loss (see [Jer 6:26](#); [Amos 8:10](#); [Zech 12:10](#)).

Luke 7:13–14

The word translated coffin may refer to a casket or a funeral bier. A Jew was rendered unclean by touching a dead body or the coffin or bier ([Lev 21:1](#), [11–12](#)). As when he touched the man with leprosy ([Luke 5:13](#)), however, Jesus was not defiled. He replaced disease and death with cleansing and life.

Luke 7:16

A great prophet: Jesus was like the Old Testament prophets Elijah and Elisha.

Luke 7:18–23

The disciples of John the Baptist: See study note on [5:33](#). John was now in prison ([3:19–20](#)), wondering whether Jesus was truly the Messiah, since he did not act like a powerful warrior-king who would overthrow the Romans. In response, Jesus defined his messianic role.

Luke 7:22

the blind see, the lame walk: A series of allusions to Isaiah ([Isa 26:19](#); [29:18–19](#); [35:5–6](#); [61:1–2](#)) defines God’s salvation as the restoration of fallen creation. Jesus did not come to overthrow Roman rule over Judea (so he omits “captives . . . will be freed” from his quotation of [Isa 61:1](#)); he came for the greater purpose of reversing the effects of sin and death.

Luke 7:23

God blesses those who do not fall away because of me: The blessing is for those who are able to put aside their

personal agendas and preconceived ideas about the Messiah and accept Jesus' path of suffering.

Luke 7:27

The quotation is from [Mal 3:1](#). In [Mal 4:5–6](#), this messenger is identified with the prophet Elijah. Though John denied that he was Elijah ([John 1:21–23](#)), he came in the spirit and power of Elijah ([Luke 1:17](#)) to prepare the way for the Messiah (see [3:4–6](#)).

Luke 7:28

Jesus praised John as the greatest person who ever lived under the old covenant. But even the least person in the Kingdom of God is greater than John. The blessings of the new covenant—free and complete forgiveness of sins, the indwelling presence of the Holy Spirit, and intimate knowledge of God—give believers in Jesus a new and greater position than even John enjoyed.

Luke 7:31–35

To what can I compare the people of this generation? Jesus compares Israel to fickle children in the marketplace who play games of make-believe. They called John the Baptist to dance (a wedding game), but the solemn prophet refused, calling them instead to mourning and repentance for their sins. Then they called on Jesus to mourn (a funeral game), but he was the bridegroom who announced the joyful celebration banquet of the Kingdom of God, so it would not have been fitting for him to mourn (cp. [Mark 2:19–20](#)).

Luke 7:33

John the Baptist didn't spend his time eating bread or drinking wine: John lived an ascetic's life of self-denial, appropriate to his prophetic role of announcing God's Kingdom, the coming judgment, and the need for repentance and cleansing.

Luke 7:35

But wisdom is shown to be right by the lives of those who follow it (or *But wisdom is justified by all her children*): In Proverbs, Wisdom is personified as a woman who calls God's people to a life of godliness and obedience to God's commands ([Prov 1:20–33](#); [8:1–9:6](#)). Wisdom's children are those who live righteously, as God's word instructs.

Luke 7:36

One of the Pharisees asked Jesus to have dinner with him: Jesus has more positive contact with the Pharisees in Luke than in the other Gospels. He was a respected teacher and healer, so it is not surprising that this Pharisee invited him

to dinner. Not all Pharisees were antagonistic—some were interested in his teaching or merely curious.

Luke 7:36–50

What Jesus said in [7:35](#) is shown in this story by one of "wisdom's children" (see study note on [7:35](#)). She is a repentant sinner (a person who turns away from sin). She shows deep gratitude for the forgiveness she has received.

Luke 7:37

- *a sinful woman*: This suggests she was known in the community as a person with a bad moral reputation. Some people think she may have been a prostitute, but the passage does not state this explicitly.
- Alabaster is a soft stone, often white, yellow, or red. People used it to make costly containers, such as this beautiful jar.

Luke 7:38

- *she stood behind Him*: At a banquet, people ate while lying on their sides around a low table, with their feet stretched out behind them. Because of this, the woman could not reach the head of Jesus to anoint him (to pour oil on him as a sign of honor), so she poured the perfume on his feet.

wipe them with her hair: In that culture, a woman normally kept her hair covered in public. Letting her hair down could bring shame and even give a husband reason for divorce. By wiping the feet of Jesus with her hair and kissing them, she showed deep respect and honor. She set aside normal social rules because she was so thankful.

Luke 7:40

But Jesus answered him: See study note on [5:22](#).

Luke 7:41

five hundred denarii: This was nearly two years' wages for a person who earned a living by working different jobs each day. In first-century Galilee, people who were poor often owed large debts to people who were wealthy.

Luke 7:43

the one who was forgiven more: Those who had been forgiven the most responded with greater gratitude and love. The woman did her extraordinary act of sacrificial love because Jesus had forgiven her sins.

Luke 7:44–46

Simon failed to show Jesus the usual acts of hospitality (ways to welcome a guest). The roads were dusty, so a servant would normally wash a guest's feet. People in the Middle East often greet guests with a kiss on both cheeks,

and this is still common today. Hosts also put olive oil on a guest's head as a way to show honor and respect.

Luke 7:47

for she has loved much: It was not that her great love for Jesus caused him to forgive her, but that the forgiveness she had already received from Jesus caused her love.

Luke 8:2

Magdalene means “from Magdala.” Madgala was a village north of Tiberias on the western side of the Sea of Galilee. Mary Magdalene plays an important role in the accounts of the burial and resurrection of Jesus (24:10; Mark 15:40, 47; John 19:25; 20:1, 18). Some people have said that Mary Magdalene was the woman in Luke 7:36–38. This idea has led to the belief that she was a former prostitute. However, the Bible does not say this, and there is no clear evidence for it.

Luke 8:2–3

as well as some women: In the time of Jesus, Jewish rabbis (religious teachers with authority) did not have women disciples. So this was unusual. Some of these women, like Joanna, came from wealthy families and gave financial support to the ministry of Jesus.

Luke 8:4–15

The parable of the farmer scattering seed shows that people respond in different ways to the message of Jesus about God's kingdom.

Luke 8:5

- A farmer would scatter *seed* and then plow it into the soil.
- The *seed* that fell on a walking path did not remain in the soil, so it was stepped on and eaten by birds.

Luke 8:6

fell among rocks: Often there was a limestone layer nine to twelve inches under the soil, so that the rain was trapped and seed sprouted quickly in the moist soil. But when the rain stopped, the sun evaporated the trapped moisture and the plant died.

Luke 8:7

fell among thorns: One type of weed looked very much like wheat as it grew, but it had larger roots and took away the moisture and nutrients that the wheat needed.

Luke 8:8

He who has ears to hear, let him hear: This meant everyone who was willing to listen.

Luke 8:10

the secrets of the Kingdom of God: What was hidden in the past about God's reign was now revealed through Jesus' words and actions. • When they look . . . they won't understand: This quote is from Isa 6:9 (Greek version), a passage repeatedly used in the New Testament to explain Israel's rejection of the gospel (see also Matt 13:14–15; Mark 4:12; John 12:40; Acts 28:26–27). In its original context, the passage refers to God's certain judgment of Israel at the hands of the Assyrians. Israel's sin and rebelliousness had taken them beyond the point of no return, so God blinded them in preparation for judgment. Those who rejected Jesus' message were blind to the truth.

Luke 8:11

the seed is the word of God: This means Jesus is preaching the good news about God's kingdom.

Luke 8:12

Satan tries to stop those who have yet to trust in Christ from understanding the truth.

Luke 8:13

Deep roots indicate spiritual depth and maturity. The Greek word translated *testing* can also mean “temptation” or “trials.”

Luke 8:16–17

A small clay lamp was filled with olive oil and placed in a space in the wall (an alcove). The message of Jesus gives light to those who listen, and it shows their true attitudes.

Luke 8:18

Pay attention, therefore, to how you listen: Compare with Proverbs 9:9.

Luke 8:19–20

Jesus had four brothers—James, Joseph, Judas, and Simon—and an unknown number of sisters (Matt 13:55; Mark 6:3). These children were probably born to Joseph and Mary after Jesus' virginal conception and birth. (On the other hand, some believe that Mary remained a lifelong virgin and that Joseph was therefore a widower with children from a previous marriage when he married Mary.)

Luke 8:21

those who hear God's word and carry it out: Jesus was not rejecting his family. He was saying that spiritual relationships, like being part of God's family, are more important than family bonds.

Luke 8:22–25

When Jesus calmed the *windstorm*, he showed his control over the elements. This act suggested he was God, since God controls the seas (see [Psalms 65:7](#); [89:9](#); [104:6–7](#); [107:23–32](#)).

Luke 8:23

A powerful windstorm came down on the lake. Severe storms often occur on the Sea of Galilee, which is in a valley surrounded by high hills.

Luke 8:24

Jesus got up and rebuked the wind and the raging waters: Just as Jesus *rebuked* demons and diseases ([4:39,41](#)), he showed his authority by rebuking the sea (compare [2 Samuel 22:16](#); [Psalms 18:15](#); [104:7](#); [106:9](#); [Isaiah 50:2](#); [Nahum 1:4](#)).

Luke 8:26

the region of the Gerasenes: Gerasa was a city in the Decapolis, located about 48 kilometers (30 miles) southeast of the Sea of Galilee. Jesus traveled to this mainly Gentile (non-Jewish) area on purpose to teach and help the people there.

Luke 8:26–39

Jesus had commanded the unclean spirit to come out of the man: This is known as an exorcism. This story showed the power Jesus has over spiritual forces. It also contrasted the healed man's faith and commitment to Jesus with the fear and rejection of people in the town.

Luke 8:27

he stayed in the tombs: Touching a tomb or a dead body made a Jew unclean, or ceremonially defiled. Jesus willingly entered this unclean place to rescue a person enslaved by Satan.

Luke 8:28

Jesus, Son of the Most High God: See study notes on [4:34](#), [41](#).

Luke 8:29

unclean spirit: The word *unclean* means not fit to be in God's presence. An unclean spirit is a spirit that opposes God and does not belong near him (see also study note on [4:33](#)).

Luke 8:30

A Roman legion included about 6,000 soldiers. This number shows that the man had many demons.

Luke 8:31

the Abyss: The Greek word *abussos* means "bottomless." It often refers to the prison of evil spirits or fallen angels under

the surface of the world ([Revelation 9:1–2](#), [11](#); [11:7](#); [17:8](#); [20:1](#), [3](#); compare [2 Peter 2:4](#)). The metaphor comes from the apparently bottomless depth of the ocean (the ancients had no means for sounding the ocean depths, so to them it was bottomless).

Luke 8:32

a large herd of pigs: Jews considered pigs to be ceremonially unclean animals. This indicates that the people in this area were Gentiles. The spiritually unclean demons were only suitable to be in pigs.

Luke 8:35

sitting at Jesus' feet: The man sat in the position of a disciple, indicating his willingness to follow Jesus (see [8:37](#)).

Luke 8:37

asked Jesus to depart from them: The power of Jesus over spiritual forces scared the people. Losing their pigs made them angry. Their rejection contrasts with the faith of the healed man.

Luke 8:39

Return home: The role of disciples is to proclaim to the world what Jesus has done for them.

Luke 8:40–56

These two accounts of healing show that Jesus has authority over disease and death. They also show the power of faith.

Luke 8:41

synagogue leader: The leader of the local synagogue was the officer who maintained the local synagogue and organized services (see also [8:49](#); [13:14](#); [Acts 13:15](#); [18:8](#), [17](#)).

Luke 8:43

with constant bleeding: Perhaps it was a menstrual disorder. The tragedy was both physical and spiritual, for such bleeding rendered the woman ceremonially unclean and thereby precluded her participation in community worship ([Lev 15:25–30](#)).

Luke 8:44

the fringe of His cloak: This likely refers to the little pieces of material (tassels) that pious Jews wore on the edges of their clothing (see [Numbers 15:38–39](#); [Deuteronomy 22:12](#)).

Luke 8:45

Who touched Me?: Jesus recognized the touch of faith by a needy person.

Luke 8:48

your faith has healed you. Go in peace: Jesus also said this to the woman who anointed his feet (7:50). The Greek word translated here as *healed* can mean spiritual or physical salvation. *Peace* (compare to the Hebrew word *shalom*) means wholeness, not only the lack of conflict (see 1:79; 2:14, 29; 7:50; 19:38, 42; 24:36).

Luke 8:51

Peter, John, and James formed a close group within the disciples of Jesus (see 5:1–11; 9:28; Mark 14:32–33).

Luke 8:52

- *everyone was weeping and mourning:* See study note on 7:12.
- *she is not dead but asleep:* Jesus emphasized that the girl's condition was temporary. For Christians, death is like being asleep for a temporary period (compare John 11:11; Acts 7:60; 13:36; 1 Corinthians 11:30; 15:6, 18, 20, 51; 1 Thessalonians 4:14–15; 5:10).

Luke 8:55

Her spirit returned: Like the raising of the widow's son (7:15), the girl's normal mortal life was restored. At the final resurrection, believers will receive glorified bodies that do not die (see study note on 24:39).

Luke 8:56

not to tell anyone: See "The Secret of the Messiah" Theme Note.

Luke 9:1–6

Jesus now sent his 12 disciples to announce the kingdom of God and demonstrate its authority by casting out demons and healing the sick. Jesus was training them to carry on his work after he was gone.

Luke 9:3

Take nothing for the journey: They were to depend on God and on the kindness of the people they served.

Luke 9:4

Whatever house you enter, stay there: They were to develop lasting relationships and be content without seeking better lodging or provisions.

Luke 9:5

shake the dust off your feet: Using a symbol of rejection, they were to leave such a town to the judgment it deserved.

Luke 9:8

Jews expected the prophet Elijah would arrive before God's final judgment (see study note on 1:17). Some Jews expected a prophet like Moses would come (Deuteronomy 18:15).

Luke 9:9

I beheaded John: See Mark 6:14–29.

Luke 9:10

- *He withdrew:* Jesus knew the disciples needed a time to focus on spiritual matters.
- Bethsaida was on the northern shore of the Sea of Galilee, east of the Jordan River. It was the hometown of Peter, Andrew, and Philip (John 1:44; 12:21).

Luke 9:10–17

The feeding of the 5,000 recalls God's miraculous feeding of Israel with manna in the wilderness (Exodus 16; see also 2 Kings 4:42–44). It points forward to God's final salvation as a great feast for all nations (Isaiah 25:6–8; 65:13–14; Luke 14:15–24).

Luke 9:11

He welcomed them: Jesus wanted to go away in private with his disciples, but he had compassion on the crowds and ministered to them.

Luke 9:13

You give them something to eat: After their ministry of healing the sick and casting out demons, Jesus wanted the disciples to demonstrate faith in God's ability to feed the crowds.

Luke 9:17

twelve basketfuls of broken pieces that were left over: God abundantly provides for his people.

Luke 9:18–27

Peter's confession that Jesus was the Christ (or Messiah) marked a turning point. Until then, Jesus had shown his authority as God's promised leader through miracles. Now he began to explain that the Messiah would suffer in an unexpected way.

Jesus accepted this confession, but he made it clear that his role as Messiah would include suffering and death. He also called his disciples to follow him no matter the cost.

Luke 9:19

others say Elijah: See study note on 9:8.

Luke 9:20

The Christ: This phrase could be translated “the LORD’s anointed,” a title for the king of Israel (1 Samuel 24:6, 10; 2 Samuel 19:21; Psalm 2:2). David was the LORD’s anointed, and so was the Christ.

Luke 9:21–22

not to tell this to anyone: Jesus did not want to inspire the people to fight against Rome. His mission was to suffer, die, and rise from the dead.

Luke 9:22

must suffer many terrible things: This was the first of Jesus’ prophecies concerning his coming death in Jerusalem (see 9:44; 17:25; 18:31–34). Jesus would fulfill Isa 52:13–53:12, in which the servant of the Lord (the Messiah) became a saving sacrifice for God’s people. These events were part of God’s purpose and plan. Despite opposition from human beings and from the spiritual forces of Satan, God works through the actions of human beings to accomplish his purposes. Though wicked men plotted against Jesus and put him to death, God accomplished salvation by raising Jesus from the dead (Luke 24:7, 26–27, 44–47; Acts 2:23–24; 3:18; 4:28).

- leading priests: Though Israel had only one high priest, the upper-class priests were the aristocracy; they served on the Sanhedrin and held positions of power in Jerusalem.

Luke 9:23

take up your cross daily: This did not simply mean carrying a heavy burden, but suffering a violent death by crucifixion. Believers must be completely willing to die to themselves and to live for God, even at the cost of their lives.

Luke 9:23–27

If anyone wants to come after me: After predicting his own suffering and death, Jesus taught that all who follow him must also experience death to self.

Luke 9:24

whoever wants to save his life: Trying to keep control of your own life instead of trusting God suggests that putting yourself in God’s place denies that Jesus is king. The result is that a person will lose true life, especially at the final judgment (9:26; John 12:25).

Luke 9:26

the Son of Man ... when He comes in His glory: See Daniel 7:13–14; “The Son of Man” Theme Note.

Luke 9:27

This difficult verse might refer to:

1. the second coming of Christ;
2. the destruction of Jerusalem in AD 70;
3. the resurrection of Jesus; or
4. the transfiguration (when the appearance of Jesus changed and his glory was shown), which immediately follows in 9:28–36.

The last possibility is the most likely.

Luke 9:28

- *About eight days later:* Mark’s Gospel says “after six days,” referring to full days. Luke only includes parts of days.
- Peter, John, and James were the disciples who were closest to Jesus (see also 8:51; Mark 14:32–33).
- *a mountain:* The traditional site of the transfiguration is Mount Tabor in southern Galilee. Some people think it was Mount Hermon, because it is closer to Caesarea Philippi, where Peter declared that Jesus is the Christ (Luke 9:18–27).

Luke 9:28–36

At the transfiguration, Jesus revealed his true glory in the presence of three disciples. This confirmed Peter’s belief that Jesus was the Christ. Moses and Elijah confirmed that Jesus fulfilled the Old Testament prophecies about the Messiah (the Christ, God’s chosen king).

Luke 9:29

His clothes became radiantly white (literally became bright as a flash of lightning): The glory of Jesus shone through his human body (compare Ezekiel 1:4; Daniel 7:9; see also Exodus 34:29).

Luke 9:31

His departure: The Greek word *exodos* means “departure.” In the Old Testament, the exodus from Egypt was God’s great act of salvation. Similarly, in the New Testament, the departure of Jesus from this world was God’s greatest act of salvation. This includes his death, resurrection, and ascension (going up into heaven). Jesus would accomplish a new and greater exodus.

Luke 9:33

Let us put up three shelters: The Greek word translated *shelter* (*skēnē*) is the same word used in the Greek Old Testament for the *tabernacle*. This was Israel’s tent for worship that they moved with them as they traveled in the wilderness. It also refers to the temporary *shelters* that Jews used during the Feast of Booths (Leviticus 23:42; Nehemiah 8:14–17). Peter might have wanted to extend the event by providing a place for Jesus, Moses, and Elijah to stay.

Luke 9:34

and enveloped them: In the Bible, clouds often cover or hide God's presence ([Exodus 16:10](#); [19:9](#); [24:16](#)).

Luke 9:35

The voice from the cloud recalls God's voice at Jesus' baptism ([3:22](#)). • *My Chosen One* alludes to [Isa 42:1](#), identifying Jesus as the suffering servant of the Lord. • Listen to him is from [Deut 18:15](#), identifying Jesus as "the prophet like Moses" (see [Acts 3:22](#); [7:37](#)).

Luke 9:38

my only child: The loss of an only son was especially tragic, since this left no one to carry on the family name (cp. [7:12](#); see [Gen 22:16](#); [1 Kgs 17:17–24](#); [Jer 6:26](#); [Amos 8:10](#); [Zech 12:10](#)).

Luke 9:39

A spirit keeps seizing him: Demons sometimes cause physical sickness, such as not being able to walk or not being able to speak ([13:11](#); [11:14](#)).

Luke 9:41

O unbelieving and perverse generation!: It is unclear whether Jesus was speaking to the disciples or to the people as a whole.

Luke 9:44

See study note on [9:22](#).

Luke 9:45

Its significance was hidden from them: The disciples were often slow to understand, partly because their eyes were blinded to the truth until after the resurrection (see study note on [Mark 6:52](#)).

Luke 9:46

Jesus had just told his disciples that he would suffer and die. Yet they began to argue about which of them was the greatest. This showed surprising pride and a lack of concern for what Jesus had just said.

Luke 9:46–50

The disciples did not understand that Jesus would soon die, which was now seen in their pride and selfish attitude.

Luke 9:47

Jesus, knowing the thoughts of their hearts: See [5:22](#); [7:39–40](#).

Luke 9:48

Anyone who welcomes a little child: To welcome means to bestow honor and to treat as a social equal. The statement is shocking, since children in Jesus' day had no social status in the community and were viewed as their parents' property. Jesus took the lowest and most vulnerable members of society and announced that welcoming them was equivalent to welcoming him. • on my behalf (literally *in my name*): This means "as my representative." • Whoever is the least among you is the greatest: True leadership in Jesus' Kingdom is achieved through sacrificial service, not the exercise of power (see also [Mark 10:42–45](#)).

Luke 9:50

Anyone who is not against you is for you: Though not one of the Twelve, the man who was casting out demons was not to be discouraged since he, too, was proclaiming the message of the Kingdom. The statement was proverbial, however, and not an absolute truth, as Jesus made the inverse statement in [11:23](#). Wisdom is needed to apply a proverb properly in a given situation.

Luke 9:51

Jesus resolutely set out for Jerusalem: Even though the route was not direct, Jerusalem was his final destination.

Luke 9:51–19:44

The journey to Jerusalem marked a new stage in the mission of Jesus as the Messiah, which would include suffering. During this time, he prepared his disciples for what was ahead, and the Jewish leaders opposed him more and more.

Luke 9:52–53

a Samaritan village: Jews and Samaritans had a history of conflict and racial prejudice; they hated each other (see study note on [10:33](#)). The Samaritans, who worshiped on Mount Gerizim, probably assumed that Jesus was traveling to Jerusalem to worship there.

Luke 9:54

call down fire from heaven to burn them up: Some manuscripts add *as Elijah did*. Three times, Elijah called down fire from heaven against the enemies of God ([1 Kgs 18:38](#); [2 Kgs 1:1–17](#)). In their zeal, James and John wanted to do the same.

Luke 9:57–62

As he traveled toward Jerusalem to suffer and die, Jesus explained the cost to those who wished to follow him.

Luke 9:58

no place to lay His head: Any disciple of Jesus must be ready to go anywhere and to give up home and security.

Luke 9:59

let me . . . bury my father: Respect for parents was a very important value in first-century Israel. Among other things, this meant providing them with an honorable burial. Jesus called for a commitment that took precedence over all human relationships.

Luke 9:61–62

let me say good-bye to my family: The statement echoes Elisha's request of Elijah ([1 Kgs 19:19–20](#)). Jesus required an even more complete commitment from his disciples. • puts a hand to the plow and then looks back: The ancient farmer guided a light plow with his left hand and his oxen with the right. Looking away would turn the plow out of its path. For a believer, looking back meant placing earthly concerns ahead of God.

Luke 10:1–20

The Lord now chose seventy-two: The mission of the Twelve ([9:1–6](#)) represented Jesus' ministry to Israel; this mission represented his outreach to the Gentiles. The number 72 represents the nations of the world. [Genesis 10](#) lists 70 nations in the Hebrew text, but the Septuagint—the Greek Old Testament—lists 72. Luke, who used the Septuagint, probably wrote 72, and then a later scribe “corrected” the text to agree with the Hebrew. The point is that the Good News is for both Jews and Gentiles.

Luke 10:2

The harvest refers to people who need to hear the Good News and be gathered to God's presence (cp. [Isa 27:12](#)). There was urgency to the task, just as crops have to be brought in at the exact time when they are ripe. More workers were needed.

Luke 10:3

lambs among wolves: Jesus' followers are not to dominate others, but to sacrifice themselves for the benefit of others. This makes them vulnerable (see [Jer 5:6](#); [Ezek 22:27](#); [Hab 1:8](#); [Zeph 3:3](#)), but the Good Shepherd ([Ps 23:1](#)) protects them from the wolves.

Luke 10:4

Don't take any money with you: Cp. [9:3](#). Jesus' disciples were to depend on God and on the help of those whom they served. • don't stop to greet anyone on the road: This did not

mean being antisocial, but staying focused on the task Jesus had given them.

Luke 10:5

God's peace means spiritual blessings and becoming whole. This is known as the shalom of God (see study note on [8:48](#)).

Luke 10:7

Don't move around from home to home: See study note on [9:4](#). • because those who work deserve their pay: Those who minister for Jesus should receive compensation from those they serve (see also [1 Cor 9:14](#); [1 Tim 5:18](#)).

Luke 10:9

The same mission was given to the Twelve (see [9:1](#)). • Heal the sick: Healing was a sign of salvation ([Isa 29:18–19](#); [35:5](#)); it was physical evidence that the Kingdom of God was present (see study note on [Luke 7:22](#)).

Luke 10:11

See study note on [9:5](#).

Luke 10:12

God destroyed Sodom and Gomorrah because of their wickedness ([Genesis 18:16–19:29](#)).

Luke 10:13

Korazin and Bethsaida, two of the towns in which Jesus ministered, were located on the northern shore of the Sea of Galilee. • Tyre and Sidon were Gentile cities in Phoenicia, on the Mediterranean coast north of Galilee. The prophets had pronounced messages of judgment against their wickedness ([Isa 23](#); [Ezek 28](#)).

Luke 10:15

Capernaum was Jesus' base of operations during his Galilean ministry; this town saw many of his miracles (see [4:31–41](#)). • to the place of the dead: Though Capernaum was blessed by the Messiah's presence, it would be judged for its pride and rejection of Jesus.

Luke 10:18

I saw Satan fall like lightning from heaven: See [Revelation 12:7–12](#).

Luke 10:19

Snakes and scorpions were symbols of danger and evil (see [Num 21:6–9](#); [Deut 8:15](#); [1 Kgs 12:14](#); [Isa 11:8](#); [Ezek 2:6](#)). Satan is the ancient serpent who tempted Eve ([Gen 3:13–14](#); [Rom 16:20](#); [Rev 12:9](#); [20:2](#)), and demonic forces are described as scorpions ([Rev 9:3–4](#)). • Nothing will injure you: This

didn't mean that Jesus' followers should take dangerous chances. The point is that God protects his servants (e.g., [Acts 28:3–6](#)).

Luke 10:20

Disciples should not rejoice in their spiritual power, but in the greatness of God who freely gives them salvation.

- your names are registered in heaven: For the record of salvation in heaven's books, see [Exod 32:32–33](#); [Ps 69:28](#); [Isa 4:3](#); [Dan 12:1](#); [Mal 3:16–17](#); [Phil 4:3](#); [Heb 12:23](#); [Rev 3:5](#); [13:8](#); [17:8](#); [20:12](#), [15](#); [21:27](#).

Luke 10:21

You have hidden these things: God uses simple things that a child can understand to shame those who think themselves wise but are foolish in God's eyes (see [Isaiah 29:14](#); [1 Corinthians 1:18–31](#)).

Luke 10:22

The Father and the Son share an intimate relationship. Jesus came to earth to reveal the Father to a lost world (see [John 1:1–18](#)).

Luke 10:23

see what you see: The disciples saw God's promised salvation come. They saw the kingdom of God begin.

Luke 10:25

an expert in the law: See study note on 5:17.

Luke 10:27

Love the Lord your God: Jesus identified [Deuteronomy 6:5](#) and [Leviticus 19:18](#) as the two most important commandments ([Mark 12:28–34](#)). [Deuteronomy 6:5](#) is part of the prayer called the *Shema*, which every Jew was to repeat daily.

Luke 10:28

Do this and you will live: Jesus was not suggesting that people would be saved by their works. Instead, such love expresses genuine faith and devotion to the Lord.

Luke 10:29

Who is my neighbor?: A neighbor, in this context, was normally identified as a fellow Israelite.

Luke 10:30

The road from Jerusalem to Jericho declined 1,000 meters (3,300 feet) through rugged terrain where robbers often waited for travelers.

Luke 10:30–37

This parable shows that true neighbors love even their enemies ([10:29](#)). True faith is not based on a person's ethnic background or religious group, but on loving God and loving others.

Luke 10:31

- *a priest*: Priests were descendants of Aaron from the tribe of Levi ([Exodus 28:1–3](#)). They served in the temple and offered sacrifices to God.
- *passed by*: If a priest or a Levite touched a dead body, they would become ceremonially unclean and could not serve in the temple. This priest was unwilling to risk ritual impurity by helping a person in serious trouble.

Luke 10:32

a Levite: Levites were members of the tribe of Levi. They were not given a tribal homeland in Israel but were dedicated to God ([Numbers 3:41](#), [45](#); [8:18](#); [35:2–3](#); [Deuteronomy 18:1](#); [Joshua 14:3](#)). They assisted priests in temple service.

Luke 10:33

a despised Samaritan: This reversal in the story must have left the listeners aghast. Jews and Samaritans hated each other (see [9:52–53](#); [17:16](#); [John 4:4–42](#)). After the Assyrians conquered the northern kingdom of Israel, Assyrian colonists intermarried with Israelites left in Samaria; these inhabitants became known as Samaritans. After the Judeans returned from Babylon, conflict arose between the Jews and the Samaritans ([Ezra 4:1–24](#)), who built a rival temple on Mount Gerizim and used their own version of the Pentateuch (Genesis–Deuteronomy) as their Scripture. Hatred between the two increased dramatically when the Jewish king John Hyrcanus attacked the Samaritans and destroyed the temple on Mount Gerizim (about 128 BC). In this context of mutual animosity, no first-century Jew would expect a despised Samaritan to help a wounded Jew. But in God's Kingdom, a despised foreigner becomes a helping neighbor!

Luke 10:34

Oil calmed the wound, and *wine* helped keep away infection.

Luke 10:38–42

Martha ... Mary: These sisters and their brother Lazarus were good friends of Jesus. They lived in Bethany, east of Jerusalem (see [John 11:1](#)).

Luke 10:39

Mary ... sat at the Lord's feet: She took the position of a disciple (compare [Acts 22:3](#)). Rabbis (Jewish religious teachers with authority) usually did not have female disciples.

Luke 10:40

Martha was distracted by all the preparations to be made: Hospitality was highly valued, and Martha was doing what people expected a woman to do in that culture. She was upset that Mary was not helping.

Luke 10:42

only one thing is necessary: Mary has discovered it. The words of Jesus were surprising. Women were expected to serve in the home, and they were not allowed to learn from a rabbi as disciples. Jesus affirmed Mary's desire to be his disciple.

Luke 11:1

praying: See study note on 3:21.

Luke 11:2–4

When you pray, say: The “Lord’s Prayer” was the way Jesus wanted his disciples to *pray*.

Luke 11:4

And lead us not into temptation: This phrase is difficult in Greek. God does not tempt his people ([James 1:13](#)). But testing is part of Christian growth ([James 1:2–4](#)), so this raises a question: Should believers pray to avoid testing?

The phrase probably means “protect us when we face temptation.”

Luke 11:6

a friend of mine has come to me on a journey: Standards of hospitality in first-century Jewish culture required a host to find adequate provisions for a visitor.

Luke 11:8

because of the man's persistence (or in order to avoid shame, or so his reputation will not be damaged): The man who refused to get up would also be shamed, because hospitality was a duty in that community. In the same way, God protects his good name by caring for his people.

Luke 11:11–12

a fish ... an egg: These were common foods. A scorpion can look like an egg when it curls into a ball. A snake or scorpion in place of food would be a cruel trick, giving something

dangerous instead of a good meal. No loving father would do that.

Luke 11:13

give the Holy Spirit: Matthew's parallel ([Matt 7:11](#)) reads “give good gifts.” The Holy Spirit is the greatest gift for believers, providing guidance, power, and the seal of salvation. Luke gives special prominence to the work of the Holy Spirit in Luke and Acts.

Luke 11:14

a demon possessed a man who could not speak: In the Gospels, physical disease or disability was sometimes caused by demons.

Luke 11:14–32

Jesus faced two challenges. He answered the first, an accusation that he was casting out demons by Satan's power ([11:15](#)), in [11:17–26](#). The second was a demand for miraculous signs ([11:16](#)), which he answered in [11:29–32](#).

Luke 11:15

Satan: Greek Beelzeboul (“Baal, the prince”), the name of a Canaanite god that later came to be used as a name for Satan. The Jews mocked the name, calling him *Beelzebub* (“lord of the flies”).

Luke 11:17

He knew their thoughts: See [5:22](#); [7:40](#); [9:47](#). • Any kingdom divided by civil war: Jesus' first response to the accusation was that he could not be working for Satan; he was tearing down Satan's kingdom by casting out demons.

Luke 11:20

The kingdom of God has come upon you: When Jesus drove out demons, he showed that the kingdom of God was present.

Luke 11:21–22

The *strong man* is Satan. Jesus is *someone stronger*. By driving out demons, Jesus showed that he was defeating Satan and taking back what belonged to him. This includes people Satan had kept in bondage (compare [Isaiah 49:24–26](#)).

Luke 11:23

He who is not with Me is against Me: See study note on 9:50.

Luke 11:26

seven other spirits: Seven may indicate completeness, meaning that the man was completely under their power, or it could simply indicate an overwhelming force.

Luke 11:28

Blessed rather: Jesus again affirmed that our spiritual life and our relationship with God are more important than physical ancestry and family relationships (compare 8:21).

Luke 11:29–30

The sign of Jonah might refer to the resurrection of Jesus. Jonah's time in the fish was a sign to the Ninevites that God had sent him, similar to the time Jesus spent in the grave ("in the heart of the earth"; [Matthew 12:40](#)). It could also mean that both Jonah and Jesus preached God's warning to repent (see [Luke 11:32](#)).

Luke 11:31

South: The Old Testament identifies this place as Sheba, a kingdom in southern Arabia. The queen traveled a long distance to hear King Solomon's wisdom ([1 Kings 10:1–13](#); [2 Chronicles 9:1–12](#)).

Luke 11:33

No one lights a lamp and puts it in a cellar or under a basket: See study note on 8:16–17.

Luke 11:35–36

Light and darkness are metaphors for good and evil ([John 1:5](#); [3:19](#); [8:12](#); [12:35](#); [Acts 26:18](#); [Romans 13:12](#); [2 Corinthians 4:6](#); [6:14](#); [Ephesians 5:8](#); [1 Thessalonians 5:5](#); [1 Peter 2:9](#); [1 John 1:5](#); [2:8–9](#)).

Luke 11:37

a Pharisee invited Him to dine with him: See study note on 7:36.

Luke 11:38

first wash before the meal: The Pharisees had developed elaborate washing rituals to ensure ceremonial purity (see [Mark 7:1–5](#)).

Luke 11:39

The Pharisees had very detailed rules for washing cups and dishes in order to be religiously clean. These rules were about ceremonial cleansing (a special washing required by religious law).

Jesus said they cleaned only the outside of the cup. By this, he meant they carefully followed outward rules. But inside, they were still unclean. They kept sin and wrong desires in their inner lives (their thoughts and motives).

Luke 11:41

give as alms: Giving to those in need is an outward action. Such actions reveal internal righteousness (a right relationship with God).

Luke 11:42

pay tithes of mint, rue, and every herb: The law required tithing (giving one tenth to God; see [Leviticus 27:30–33](#); [Numbers 18:21–32](#); [Deuteronomy 14:22–29](#); [2 Chronicles 31:5–12](#)). The Pharisees were careful to tithe everything correctly. But they ignored what was more important: justice and the love of God.

Luke 11:42–52

What sorrow awaits you Pharisees! Woes are the opposite of blessings (see study note on 6:24–26). Jesus pronounced six woes, three against the Pharisees ([11:42](#), [43](#), [44](#)) and three against the teachers of religious law ([11:46](#), [47](#), [52](#)).

Luke 11:43

- The elders of the synagogues had special seats of honor.
- The respectful greetings were honorable ways of addressing social and religious superiors. For example, people might use a special title when speaking to a leader, teacher, or judge to show respect.

Luke 11:44

unmarked graves: Touching a grave or a dead body made a Jew ceremonially unclean. Jesus accused the religious leaders of being a defiling influence rather than a purifying one. This was a strongly offensive accusation ([11:45](#)).

Luke 11:45

experts in the law: The experts in religious law were closely aligned with the Pharisees and shared the same zeal for keeping the law of Moses.

Luke 11:46

heavy burdens: This refers to the oral tradition with all its intricate details on living according to *torah* (God's instruction in the books of Moses). The oral tradition placed a great burden upon the Jewish people.

Luke 11:48

They killed the prophets: See [1 Kings 19:10](#), [14](#); [Nehemiah 9:26](#); [Jeremiah 2:30](#); [26:20–24](#). Luke presents Jesus as the suffering prophet ([Luke 4:22–24](#)). The suffering prophet is a prophet sent by God who is rejected and suffers. Luke shows that Jesus fits this pattern.

Luke 11:49

The quotation is not explicitly from the Old Testament.

Luke 11:51

from the blood of Abel to the blood of Zechariah: Abel's murder by his brother Cain was the first murder recorded in the Old Testament ([Genesis 4:8](#)). The stoning of Zechariah, son of Jehoiada ([2 Chronicles 24:20–22](#)), was the last, since Chronicles is the last book in the Hebrew Bible.

Luke 11:52

the key to knowledge: See [Matthew 16:19](#); [23:13](#).

Luke 12:1

Yeast spreads through dough until it is entirely leavened. Leaven became a symbol of sin's spreading power ([Exodus 12:14–20](#); [1 Corinthians 5:6](#)). Like yeast, the hypocrisy of the Pharisees would spread until it affected all the people.

Luke 12:2–3

These verses warn against hypocrisy (pretending to be good or righteous). All thoughts will be revealed by God, who knows all things and will judge every human being ([Job 10:4–7](#); [11:11](#); [Psalms 11:4](#); [33:15](#); [139:12](#); [Proverbs 15:3](#)).

Luke 12:5

hell (Greek Gehenna): The Valley of Hinnom was a ravine along the southwestern side of Jerusalem. It became a metaphor for hell because Israelites had offered their children as sacrifices there ([Jer 32:35](#)) and later used it as a place to burn garbage ([Jer 19:2](#), [10–13](#)). Jesus' disciples should never be afraid of enemies who can only take away their life on earth. Instead, they should fear God, who can give eternal punishment.

Luke 12:6

Each of the *two pennies* was worth about half an hour of work for a person who earned a living by working day jobs.

Luke 12:8

will also confess him before the angels of God: At the final judgment (see [Daniel 7:7–14](#)).

Luke 12:10

The Holy Spirit draws people to God. One who blasphemes the Holy Spirit rejects his testimony about Jesus and so rejects God. This is the unpardonable sin (see study notes on Matt 12:31–32).

Luke 12:11–12

brought before synagogues: Jesus predicted persecution from Jews in the synagogues and from Gentile rulers and authorities. Paul and other apostles faced both kinds of persecution throughout Acts.

Luke 12:13

tell my brother to divide our father's estate: In Judaism, the oldest son received a double portion of the inheritance ([Deut 21:17](#)) and was responsible for dividing up the rest after his father's death. This younger brother wanted his share of the estate (cp. [Luke 15:11–32](#)).

Luke 12:13–21

This parable shows the danger of trusting in riches instead of in God.

Luke 12:15

Guard yourselves against every form of greed: See [Exodus 20:17](#); [Deuteronomy 5:21](#); [Job 31:24–25](#); [Psalm 49](#); [Ecclesiastes 2:1–11](#).

Luke 12:16–20

On the surface, the rich man had a perfectly prudent plan, but the constant focus was on himself (cp. [Eccl 5:10](#)); he never considered giving crops to the needy. He assumed that his riches would last and only wanted a place to store them, without bringing God into the equation at all ([Jas 4:13–17](#)). His judgment was just.

Luke 12:19–20

My friend: Literally *Soul*. The man was speaking to himself. • You fool! In Scripture, a fool is not someone with a low intelligence, but one who dishonors and disobeys God ([Ps 14:1–5](#)). • You will die (literally *Your soul will be demanded from you*): The man was satisfied with his soul, but God was not.

Luke 12:22–34

Jesus' warning against greed ([12:13–21](#)) is followed by teaching about living in dependence on God. Jesus' disciples were to focus on God's Kingdom and his purpose in this world rather than being obsessed with possessions.

Luke 12:24

Consider the ravens: Ravens were ceremonially unclean ([Leviticus 11:15](#); [Deuteronomy 14:14](#)). But God cared even for them ([Psalm 147:9](#)).

Luke 12:25

add a single hour to his life (literally *add a single cubit to his length*): Worry cannot make life any longer.

Luke 12:27

King Solomon was one of the wealthiest kings in the world during his time (see [2 Chronicles 9:13–22](#)).

Luke 12:30

the Gentiles: The Greek word *ethnē* can mean “the nations” or “the Gentiles.” To a Jewish audience, it meant all who were not God’s people.

Luke 12:31

seek His kingdom: Live God’s way, follow his purpose, and obey him.

Luke 12:32

little flock: God is the shepherd of his people ([Psalm 23](#); [Jeremiah 13:17](#); [Ezekiel 34](#); [Zechariah 10:3](#)). Israel’s leaders were also known as shepherds. The prophets criticized them for harming or neglecting their people (“flock”; [Ezekiel 34](#); [Zechariah 10:3](#)).

Luke 12:33

Sell your possessions and give to those in need: This is not a command to liquidate all personal possessions, since elsewhere in the Bible it is assumed that believers will own property. It means recognizing that everything we have is God’s and should be used to serve him and his people (see [Acts 2:44–45](#); [4:32–34](#)). Believers are responsible for meeting the needs of the poor, especially in the church ([Gal 6:10](#)). • treasure for you in heaven: See [Luke 16:1–13](#); [Matt 6:19–21](#). When God gives wealth, he also gives a ministry to help the unfortunate.

Luke 12:35

keep your lamps burning: This is a picture of being ready and staying watchful ([Exodus 27:20–21](#); [Leviticus 24:2](#); [Psalm 18:28](#); [Matthew 25:1–13](#)).

Luke 12:35–48

Jesus compared his faithful followers to servants in a master’s house. These servants were always ready for his return and did a good job managing the resources he left with them.

Luke 12:36

The master could return from the *wedding banquet* at any time of day or night. The followers of Jesus should always remain faithful and prepared for his return.

Luke 12:37

he himself will seat them: In Middle Eastern culture, the master would never serve his servants! Jesus redefined the role of the master by serving his disciples, giving himself for them, and meeting all their needs (see [22:24–27](#)). • An apron was typical garb for a servant.

Luke 12:40

the Son of Man will come: See “The Son of Man” Theme Note.

Luke 12:42

The faithful, sensible servant was a household manager. Wealthy homeowners appointed gifted and educated slaves as chief executive officers over their affairs.

Luke 12:44

in charge of all he owns: Although servants in the Roman world were slaves (the master’s property), they could rise to very high social status, owning property, managing the entire household, and acting with the master’s authority.

Luke 12:46

he will cut the servant in pieces: Such brutal judgment was common in the ancient world. It is uncertain whether Jesus was talking about temporal punishment or eternal damnation. • and banish him with the unfaithful: This could either mean “treat him as an unbeliever” (a temporal judgment) or “send him to hell” (an eternal judgment), depending on whether Jesus was referring to discipline for a believer or condemnation of an unbeliever. The point is that an unfaithful servant faces stringent judgment.

Luke 12:47–48

who knows . . . who does not know: Sins of ignorance receive less punishment than intentional sins ([Num 15:22–26](#); [Ps 19:13](#); cp. [Luke 23:34](#)). • When someone has been given much: Believers will be held responsible for the knowledge and resources they have been given (see [Jas 3:1](#)). A sin in ignorance is still a sin.

Luke 12:49

I have come to set the world on fire: Jesus’ ministry radically changed the status quo, bringing judgment on the wicked and purifying the righteous (see [3:16–17](#); [9:54](#); [17:29](#); [Deut 4:24](#); [Amos 5:6](#); [Heb 12:29](#)).

Luke 12:50

a baptism to undergo: The Scriptures often describe God’s judgment as an overwhelming flood ([Psalms 18:4](#); [42:7](#); [69:1–2](#); [Isaiah 8:7–8](#); [30:27–28](#); [Jonah 2:5](#)).

Luke 12:51–53

No, I tell you, but division: The ministry of Jesus demands a decision for or against God that divides even family members.

Luke 12:53

Jesus quotes [Micah 7:6](#), which was interpreted by the rabbis as the crisis and persecution that would lead to the Messiah's coming.

Luke 12:54

Clouds beginning to form in the west brought rain from the Mediterranean Sea.

Luke 12:55

The hot south wind blows into Israel from the Arabian Desert to the south and east ([Job 37:17](#); [Jeremiah 4:11](#)).

Luke 12:58

on your way to the magistrate: This case involved an unpaid debt and could lead to prison for the debtor. The officer was either a court official or a prison guard. It was wise to settle matters with your accuser before reaching the court. In the same way, people should make things right with God before the final judgment.

Luke 13:1

the Galileans whose blood Pilate had mixed with their sacrifices: This specific event is not mentioned in other known sources. But Pilate was a harsh governor who violently put down unrest on several occasions (see Josephus, *War* 2.9.2–4; *Antiquities* 18.3.1–2).

Luke 13:1–4

Jesus was responding to a popular claim that bad things only happen to bad people. Sin has negative consequences, but not every bad thing is a result of sin. Jesus then clarified that all people are sinners who need to repent ([13:3](#), [5](#); see [Job 4:7](#); [8:4](#), [20](#); [22:5](#); see also [Pss 34:21](#); [75:10](#); [Prov 3:33](#); [10:3](#), [6–7](#), [16](#), [24–25](#); [John 9:2–3](#)).

Luke 13:4

when the tower in Siloam fell: This incident is also unknown apart from this reference. The pool of Siloam was a reservoir in the southeastern corner of Jerusalem, so the tower might have been part of the southern wall of Jerusalem.

Luke 13:6

a fig tree: People sometimes described Israel as a fig tree without fruit or a vineyard that God would

judge ([Isaiah 5:1–7](#); [Micah 7:1–2](#); see [Jeremiah 8:13](#); [24:1–10](#); [Hosea 9:10](#)).

Luke 13:6–9

The parable of the barren fig tree (a story about a tree that does not produce fruit) shows the ministry of Jesus to Israel. If the nation did not produce the fruit of repentance (turning away from sin), it would face judgment. The story does not give a final ending, which shows that Israel still had a chance to respond. Compare with [Matthew 21:18–19](#) and the similar passage in [Mark 11:12–14](#).

Luke 13:9

cut it down: A stump or fallen tree symbolized judgement or destruction (compare [3:9](#); see also [Isaiah 6:13](#); [10:34](#); [11:1](#); [Jeremiah 46:22](#); [Daniel 4:23](#); [Matthew 3:10](#); [7:19](#)).

Luke 13:10

Jesus was teaching in one of the synagogues (see [4:14–30](#)): Visiting Jewish rabbis (religious teachers with authority) often taught after reading the Law and the Prophets in the synagogue.

Luke 13:11

disabled by a spirit: See study note on [11:14](#).

Luke 13:14

not on the Sabbath: Jewish rabbis (religious teachers with authority) debated whether people should give medical help on the Sabbath day. They decided it was suitable only in extreme emergencies.

Luke 13:15–16

- *You hypocrites!* Hypocrites are people who pretend to be good or righteous, saying one thing but doing another. The religious leaders would care for their own animals on the Sabbath, but they would not help another person in need.

There is also a play on words in the text. The same word is used for “untie” ([13:15](#)) and “released” ([13:16](#)). The leaders would free their animals but not a *daughter of Abraham*, one of God's chosen people.

- *whom Satan has kept bound:* This means she was under the power of Satan. Jesus drove out demons and healed people, which showed the kingdom of God (God's rule) and the defeat of Satan (see [11:20](#)).

Luke 13:17

Jesus gave a wise answer that made his enemies feel shame and fall silent. In Jewish society, honor was a very important value.

Luke 13:18–21

The parables of the mustard seed and the yeast reveal the nature of the kingdom of God. Like a mustard seed, it grows from a tiny size until it becomes large. Like yeast (*leaven*) in dough, it spreads through everything.

Luke 13:19

the birds of the air nested in its branches: The birds represent people who see the kingdom as a safe and secure place.

Luke 13:21

It is like the leaven: Leaven (or yeast) can represent evil (see 12:1; 1 Corinthians 5:6; Galatians 5:9). But here it shows the positive, spreading, and transforming power of the kingdom.

Luke 13:23

will only a few people be saved?: Some believed that only a small number would be saved. Others thought that all Jews would be saved because they were descendants of Abraham (see study note on 3:8).

Luke 13:25

- *After the master of the house gets up and shuts the door:* At a banquet or feast, the master locks the door after the guests with an invitation arrive.
- *I do not know where you are from:* In Scripture, *knowing* often means being chosen by God for a special relationship (Isaiah 63:16; Jeremiah 1:5; Amos 3:2). The people of Israel were God's chosen people. They came from Abraham's family line (*where you are from*), but those who failed to respond to the invitation did not have a relationship with God. The same can be said of all who fail to respond to the good news of the kingdom of God.

Luke 13:28

- The phrase *weeping and gnashing of teeth* shows rejection and suffering.
- Abraham, Isaac, and Jacob were the three main founding fathers (patriarchs) of Israel.

Luke 13:29

Although many Israelites, God's chosen people, have rejected the gospel, people from all over the world will accept God's offer of salvation and attend the future banquet of the Messiah (see 14:15; 17:20; Isaiah 2:2; 25:6–8; 51:4; 52:10; 55:5; 56:7; 59:19; Micah 4:1–2; Zechariah 2:13; Malachi 1:11).

Luke 13:32

- *Go tell that fox:* In the first century AD, Jews saw foxes as harmful and animals that had no worth.

- *driving out demons and healing people:* These actions showed that the kingdom of God was already present. His resurrection on the third day would later show that he truly brought in God's kingdom.

Luke 13:33

a prophet to perish: See “The Suffering Prophet” Theme Note.

Luke 13:34

as a hen gathers her chicks: Compare Deuteronomy 32:11; Ruth 2:12; Psalms 17:8; 36:7; 57:1; 61:4; 63:7; 91:4.

Luke 13:35

your house is abandoned: Jesus predicted the destruction of Jerusalem that took place in AD 70. • Blessings on the one who comes in the name of the Lord! This refers to Ps 118:26. Psalm 118 was one of the psalms sung by pilgrims going up to Jerusalem for the annual festivals. Here Jesus referred to his second coming.

Luke 14:1

in the home of a leading Pharisee: In the Gospel of Luke, Jesus often eats with others.

Luke 14:2

a man with dropsy: Dropsy, medically known as edema, is an accumulation of fluid in tissues or a body cavity that causes swelling. It is usually a symptom of a more serious illness.

Luke 14:3

Is it lawful to heal on the Sabbath or not?: The Jewish rabbis (religious teachers with authority) debated this question (see study note on 6:6–7).

Luke 14:5

Jesus pointed out the hypocrisy of the Pharisees. Hypocrisy means pretending to be righteous while acting differently. See also study note on 13:15–16.

Luke 14:7

the places of honor: Meals in the ancient world showed social status. A person's place at the table depended on that status. The food each guest received could also reflect status. These guests were trying to get the places of highest honor.

Luke 14:8

The response of Jesus comments on a teaching found in Proverbs 25:6–7. In that passage, wisdom warns people not to take places of honor for themselves. Instead, they should wait to be invited to a higher place. When Jesus gave his response, he applied this wisdom to his own time. He taught

that people should not seek honor for themselves. Instead, they should be humble and allow God or others to honor them.

Luke 14:9

in humiliation: In first-century Jewish culture, honor was very important. This kind of humiliation would have been almost worse than death.

Luke 14:12–13

do not invite your friends: Jesus challenged the common use of banquets to show and increase social status in the community. A host would invite friends of similar status and a few people of higher status. Those honored guests were then expected to invite the host back, which could improve the host's reputation and position.

Jesus turned this social order upside down by telling his followers to invite people who had no status and could not repay them. In this way, God invites sinful people to share in his banquet of salvation.

Luke 14:14

the resurrection of the righteous: See [Daniel 12:2](#).

Luke 14:15–24

This parable shows what was happening in the ministry of Jesus. The rich, powerful, and important people rejected his invitation to God's banquet of salvation, so they would be left out. Meanwhile, poor people and outcasts accepted the invitation (see also [1:52–53](#); [6:21, 25](#); [10:15](#); [18:14](#)).

Luke 14:17

Come, for everything is now ready: The invitations had been sent earlier. The guests were called when the meal was ready.

Luke 14:18

they all began making excuses: All such excuses would have been a great affront to the host, who had made a great investment in this important social event. These guests had previously accepted the invitation, and all of their excuses were weak. Clearly, they just didn't want to attend the banquet. • I have just bought a field and must inspect it: No one would buy a field without first inspecting it.

Luke 14:19

oxen, and I am going to try them out: This is another weak excuse. No one would buy oxen without having seen them plow.

Luke 14:20

I just got married: Some see this as a legitimate excuse since the Old Testament exempted men from military service in their first year of marriage ([Deut 20:7](#); [24:5](#)), but this feast was a local community event, not a distant war. Furthermore, in an Israelite village, a marriage and a banquet would never be planned at the same time, so there was no real conflict.

Luke 14:21

The poor, the crippled, the blind, and the lame were often treated as outsiders in Israel. Jesus reached out to them and helped them.

Luke 14:23

Go out to the highways and hedges: These people invited might refer to the Gentile, who later received the good news about Jesus and the kingdom of God (compare [Acts 9:15](#); [13:46–48](#); [18:4–6](#); [Romans 11:11–12](#)).

Luke 14:25–35

large crowds were traveling with Jesus: Jesus was very popular, but he was about to teach that the cost of following him was also very high.

Luke 14:26

If anyone comes to Me and does not hate ... even his own life: Following Jesus requires complete dedication. For the Christian, love for family and one's own life must not compete with devotion to Christ.

Luke 14:27

carry his cross: This symbolizes rejecting personal desires. A criminal sentenced to crucifixion would carry the horizontal beam of the cross to the place where the authorities would kill them.

Luke 14:34

Salt . . . if it loses its flavor: Sodium chloride cannot actually lose its saltiness. Jesus might be speaking hypothetically (if salt were to lose), or he might be referring to a combination of minerals that included salt. The salt around the Dead Sea was a mixture of sodium chloride and other minerals. When the sodium chloride was removed, what was left behind was "salt" without saltiness.

Luke 14:35

good neither for the soil nor for the manure pile: Salt had various uses in the ancient world, including flavoring ([14:34](#)), preserving, and weed-killing. The sludge left after removing the sodium chloride was useless.

Luke 15:1

People greatly disliked *tax collectors* because they worked for the hated Roman authorities. The tax collectors had a reputation for not being honest.

Luke 15:1–32

Chapter 15 contains three related parables of things lost and found: a sheep (15:1–7), a coin (15:8–10), and a son (15:11–32). The loss of something loved causes deep sorrow, whereas finding it brings great joy. There is great rejoicing in heaven when lost sinners return to their heavenly Father.

Luke 15:2

In their self-righteous hard-heartedness, the Pharisees and teachers of religious law did not care about lost people. Jesus embodied the heart of God, who longs for his wayward children to return.

Luke 15:4

A flock of a hundred sheep was of average size for a shepherd of modest means. God's people are often identified as the Lord's flock (Ps 23; Isa 53:6; Jer 13:17; Ezek 34; Zech 10:3). • leave the ninety-nine others: Other shepherds could watch the ninety-nine, so those left behind were not in danger. The shepherd would do anything to find the one that was lost.

Luke 15:8

ten silver coins: These coins might have been part of the woman's dowry. • light a lamp and sweep the entire house: Palestinian homes were poorly lit and normally had dirt or stone floors. Finding a small coin could be difficult.

Luke 15:11–32

Like the previous two parables (15:3–7, 8–10), the parable of the lost son demonstrates God's love for the lost and the joy he experiences when they return. It also allegorizes Jesus' ministry. The father represents God, the younger brother represents the tax collectors and sinners to whom Jesus ministered, and the older brother represents the religious leaders.

Luke 15:12

give me my share of the estate: At this time, this shocking request would basically mean, "To me, you are dead." He could not say anything more insulting to his father.

Luke 15:13

he wasted all his money in wild living: Jews considered the loss of family property to Gentiles in a distant land to be

particularly disgraceful and grounds for excommunication (see also Deut 21:18–21).

Luke 15:15

Pigs were ceremonially unclean animals (Leviticus 11:7; Deuteronomy 14:8). So this was the most shameful job a Jew could have.

Luke 15:20

- *his father saw him:* The father was watching the road, hoping his son would return.
- *He ran to his son:* Since running was not appropriate for the leader of the family, this expressed how happy the father was that his son came back.

Luke 15:21

The son delivered the speech he had practiced. Some early Greek manuscripts add *Please take me on as a hired servant*. The absence of this sentence in the majority of the manuscripts suggests his father interrupted him before he could finish what he wanted to say.

Luke 15:22

The finest robe belonged to the father; it affirmed the son's role as an heir and a cherished member of the household.

- Get a ring for his finger: A ring was a symbol of authority. Like the robe, it indicated his status as son and heir.

Luke 15:23

The father had been preparing a calf for a feast. He welcomed his son with the kind of honor shown to an important guest.

Luke 15:28

The older brother was angry that his father would forgive such a sinner when he, the faithful son, had worked hard to achieve his position. Like the religious leaders, he refused to rejoice when his brother was found.

Luke 15:30

this son of yours: He refused to acknowledge his own relationship to his brother.

Luke 15:31

you are always with me: The parable ends without telling us how the older brother responded. In the same way, the religious leaders still had a chance to respond to the offer of the kingdom.

Luke 16:1

There was a rich man whose manager: Wealthy landowners commonly put managers over their estates.

Luke 16:2

Turn in an account of your management: This financial statement was probably meant for the person who would replace the manager.

Luke 16:3

too ashamed to beg: The Jewish wisdom writer Sirach said, “It is better to die than to beg” (*Sirach* 40:28). This reflects how many Jews viewed begging.

Luke 16:5–7

The manager called in his master’s debtors and reduced their debts. He made friends who would help him when he no longer had a job.

Luke 16:6

A hundred measures of olive oil ... fifty: The measure in Greek is a *batos* (from the Hebrew *bath*), a standard unit for measuring liquids. A hundred measures could have been about 3,000 liters (800 gallons), and fifty measures about 1,500 liters (400 gallons). The exact sizes are uncertain.

Luke 16:7

A hundred measures ... eighty: The Hebrew word for *measures* here is *cor*. This was the standard dry measure. A hundred measures could have been around 35,000 liters (9,300 gallons or 1,000 bushels) and eighty measures around 28,000 liters (7,400 gallons or 800 bushels). The exact size of the *cor* is uncertain.

Luke 16:8

The ways of the world are the opposite of God’s ways. The children of this world use all their resources to get ahead in this world. God’s people do just the opposite (16:9). • The children of the light are the people of God (see [John 12:36](#); [1 Thes 5:5](#)).

Luke 16:8–9

Jesus seems to praise the manager for acting wisely, not for being dishonest. It likely means that believers should use their resources wisely as they prepare for eternity.

Luke 16:9

worldly resources: This is a better translation than the traditional “mammon of unrighteousness” (KJV). Believers are to use their resources wisely for spiritual benefit. • they will welcome you to an eternal home: *They* are probably

the friends. Just as the manager’s friends would give him security, the friends we win to the Kingdom will warmly welcome us for eternity.

Luke 16:13

No servant can serve two masters: Complete love and devotion can be given only to one master.

Luke 16:14

The Pharisees ... heard all of this and were scoffing: People often thought wealth was a reward from God, so the Pharisees rejected the warning Jesus spoke about money.

Luke 16:16

John the Baptist was a transitional figure—the last in the line of Old Testament prophets and the herald of the age of salvation (see [1:5–25](#), [57–80](#); [3:1–20](#); [7:18–35](#)). • everyone is eager to get in: The verb normally means “to suffer violence” and may have the negative sense of violent force into or against the Kingdom (see [Matt 11:12](#)). More likely, it carries here a positive sense of urgency to enter the Kingdom.

Luke 16:17

that doesn’t mean that the law has lost its force: Although the new covenant fulfilled the Old Testament law and prophets, the law has not passed away (however, cp. [Acts 15:23–29](#)). • Heaven and earth will be destroyed and replaced by a new heaven and earth at the end of the age ([Rev 21:1](#)), but God’s word endures forever ([Ps 119:89](#), [160](#); [Isa 40:8](#); [55:10–11](#)).

Luke 16:18

This example fit the context by showing that Jesus’ authoritative words interpreted and fulfilled the Old Testament law. • a man who divorces his wife and marries someone else commits adultery: The Old Testament allowed for divorce but did not sanction it ([Deut 24:1–4](#)), and the rabbis of Jesus’ day debated what constituted legitimate grounds. The school of Shammai allowed a man to divorce his wife only because of unfaithfulness, while the school of Hillel allowed divorce for almost any reason. Against such a casual attitude, Jesus said that breaking the marriage vow by divorce and marrying someone else was equivalent to adultery. Elsewhere ([Matt 5:32](#); [19:9](#)), Jesus provided a clear exception for cases of unfaithfulness.

Luke 16:19

Purple was the color worn by royal people. Phoenician purple was an expensive dye made from mollusks.

Luke 16:19–31

This parable repeats the warning about the danger of riches (16:13–15). It also returns to the idea that when God’s Kingdom comes, many situations will be reversed (changed to the opposite).

The rich, proud, and powerful will be brought low, while the poor, humble, and oppressed will be lifted up.

Luke 16:21

Even the dogs came and licked his sores: This is an image of misery and poverty. In Jewish culture, dogs were seen as unclean animals and scavengers (animals that eat what others leave behind).

Luke 16:22

carried by the angels to Abraham’s side: The Greek suggests a banquet at which guests reclined around a low table (see [John 13:23](#)). Lazarus was taken to the messianic banquet in the kingdom of God (see [Luke 14:1–24](#)).

Luke 16:23

Hades: This can refer to either the place where all people go when they die, or where the wicked go after death, as in this context.

Luke 16:24

- *send Lazarus:* Ironically, the man was still treating Lazarus as a lowly servant.
- *I am in agony in this fire:* See [Matthew 25:41](#); [Revelation 20:10](#), 14–15.

Luke 16:26

nor can anyone cross from there to us: This verse gives the general principle that a person’s state after death is permanent.

Luke 16:31

they will not be persuaded even if someone rises from the dead: Wicked people refuse to repent even when faced with overwhelming evidence of the truth.

Luke 17:1

- *Woe!:* This is a strong warning or expression of sorrow. In the Bible, it often introduces a message of judgment. See study notes on 6:24–26; 11:42–52.
- *the one through whom they come:* Leaders have more responsibility because they have to give an account for themselves and those they lead (see [James 3:1](#)).

Luke 17:2

A millstone is a large, round stone with a hole in its center. People used it to grind grain in a mill. A millstone could weigh hundreds of pounds.

Luke 17:4

Even if he sins against you seven times in a day: The number seven here does not mean an exact number, but rather “many times” (see [Psalm 119:164](#)). See [Matthew 18:21–22](#).

Luke 17:6

- *A mustard seed* was a common example of something very small (see [13:19](#)).
- *you can say to this mulberry tree, ‘Be uprooted’:* Black mulberry trees can live for hundreds of years and have wide and deep roots, making them very hard to pull out of the ground.
- *it will obey you:* This does not mean people should use faith to perform random miracles. God has unlimited power, and those who trust him will see him act according to his will.

Luke 17:7–10

In Greco-Roman culture, servants were expected to serve their masters faithfully. Faith (17:5–6) includes obeying Christ and submitting to his commands.

Luke 17:11

While Jesus was on his way to Jerusalem: see study note on 9:51–19:44.

Luke 17:11–19

This healing reveals the compassion and power of Jesus. In Luke, the blessings of salvation are joyfully received by many outside Israel.

Luke 17:12

They stood at a distance: See study note on 5:12. People with leprosy had to stay away from others and shout, “Unclean, unclean!” ([Leviticus 13:45–46](#)).

Luke 17:14

- *“Go, show yourselves to the priests.”:* [Leviticus 14:2–32](#) guides priests on how to determine what is leprosy and declare a leper ceremonially clean (see study notes on Luke 5:12, 14).
- *as they were in their way:* To leave without yet being healed required faith, which Jesus was testing (compare [2 Kings 5:9–14](#)).

Luke 17:16

The one man who returned to thank Jesus was a Samaritan, a hated foreigner in the eyes of most Jews (see study note on 10:33).

Luke 17:19

your faith has made you well! (or *your faith has saved you*): The Greek verb can refer to either physical or spiritual healing. The physical healings of Jesus show the salvation that his kingdom brings.

Luke 17:20–21

- *When the kingdom of God would come*: Many Jews believed that the Messiah (Christ) would establish God's kingdom in Jerusalem. They expected him to defeat Israel's enemies and bring peace, prosperity, justice, and righteousness (see 3:15; compare Acts 1:6).

The Pharisees were likely questioning the claim that Jesus was the Messiah (God's chosen king). He was not defeating the Romans or setting up a visible kingdom on earth, as they expected. Jesus did not deny this future aspect of the kingdom (see Luke 21:27; Matthew 24:30–31). But he explained that the kingdom of God was being revealed through his ministry, though they were missing it.

- *The kingdom of God will not come with observable signs*: Jewish writings in the time of Jesus expected visible signs in the sky to announce the Messiah's kingdom. Jesus confirmed that such signs would appear (see Luke 17:24; 21:25; Acts 2:19–20). But the Pharisees were missing how God's kingdom was already being shown in the ministry of Jesus at that time (compare Luke 7:22).
- *the kingdom of God is in your midst* (or *is within you, or is in your grasp*): The kingdom of God was already being shown through the words and actions of Jesus. It is unlikely that Jesus would say, "*the kingdom of God is in your midst*," to those rejecting his message.

Luke 17:20–37

This is the first of two teachings in the Gospel of Luke about the coming of the kingdom of God and the return of the Son of Man (a title Jesus uses for himself). The second teaching appears later in chapter 21.

Luke 17:22

you will long to see one of the days of the Son of Man: This may refer to his time on earth with his disciples or to the time of his second coming.

Luke 17:23–24

People will tell you, 'Look, there is the Son of Man': False Messiahs have arisen throughout history, but expectations

for the Messiah were particularly high in the first century, as a variety of figures claimed to be God's agents of deliverance (see Acts 5:36–37; 21:38). Jesus warned his disciples not to follow these imposters. • For as the lightning flashes: Lightning lights up the whole sky and is visible to everyone in the area. Similarly, when Jesus suddenly returns, it will be evident to everyone.

Luke 17:25

suffer many things: Jesus would soon die by crucifixion (see study note on 9:22). Crucifixion was a form of execution used by the Romans. The victim was nailed or tied to a wooden cross and left to die.

Luke 17:26–29

in the days of Noah ... in the days of Lot: See Genesis 6–9 for Noah and Genesis 18:16–19:29 for Lot. Both stories describe God's severe judgment against human evil.

Luke 17:32–33

Lot's wife turned into a pillar of salt when she looked longingly back at Sodom (Genesis 19:26). She is an example of those who hold on to their old way of life instead of trusting God.

Luke 17:34–35

one will be taken and the other left: The comparisons to God's judgment in the great flood and against Sodom (17:26–29), and the reference to vultures and a dead body (17:37), suggest that this separation happens at the final judgment. This is when the wicked are taken away in judgment and the righteous are left (see Malachi 3:18; Matthew 25:32).

Luke 17:37

so these signs indicate that the end is near: This clause, which does not appear explicitly in the Greek, explains the significance of the cryptic saying about the vulture.

Luke 18:1–8

The parable of the persistent widow follows naturally from the teaching of Jesus about coming troubles (17:20–37). Believers can face trials and persevere through persistent prayer.

Luke 18:2

a judge who neither feared God nor respected men: The two most important attributes for a good judge are regard for justice (fear of God), and compassion for people (see 2 Chronicles 19:6–7). This judge had neither.

Luke 18:3

A widow: God is concerned for widows, orphans, and foreigners—the most vulnerable members of ancient society—and has promised judgment against those who oppress them (Exod 22:22; Deut 10:18; 24:17; 27:19; Ps 68:5; Isa 1:23; 10:2; Jer 22:3; Ezek 22:7; Amos 5:10–13; Zech 7:10; Mal 3:5). • Give me justice: The woman was in the right in this dispute—she was not asking for special favors.

Luke 18:5

driving me crazy: This colorful Greek expression literally means “striking the eye” or “giving me a black eye,” as in boxing. The sense is of wearing someone down through persistence.

Luke 18:7

Will not God bring about justice: If persistence resulted in justice from this unjust judge, how much more will God, who loves both people and justice, answer our prayers.

Luke 18:8

when the Son of Man returns: This is an allusion to Dan 7:13–14. • how many will he find on the earth who have faith? The question is whether believers will remain faithful through the trials that will precede the coming of the Son of Man (see Matt 24:10–12; 2 Thes 2:3; 1 Tim 4:1).

Luke 18:9–14

The topic of prayer (18:1–8) leads into this parable about the right attitude for approaching God.

Luke 18:10

a tax collector: See study note on 3:12.

Luke 18:12

I fast twice a week, and I give you a tenth of my income: Fasting and tithing were signs of piety in Judaism. The law required fasting only once a year (Lev 16:29–31), but pious Jews in Jesus’ day fasted twice a week (see also Luke 5:33; 11:41–42).

Luke 18:13

he beat his breast: This action showed deep sorrow and repentance (turning away from sin).

Luke 18:14

Jesus’ conclusion that only the tax collector went home justified before God would have shocked Jesus’ audience, who regarded Pharisees as righteous and tax collectors as wicked. • those who exalt themselves will be humbled: See 1:52–53; 6:21, 25; 10:15; 14:11; 16:19–31.

Luke 18:15–17

This incident illustrates 18:14. • they scolded the parents: In this cultural context, children had no social status (see study note on 9:48), so the disciples viewed them as an interruption to Jesus’ important ministry.

Luke 18:17

receive the kingdom of God like a little child: Entrance into the kingdom of God requires childlike faith and dependence on God.

Luke 18:18

- The man was probably a religious leader, not a political ruler.
- *what must I do to inherit eternal life?:* This question was commonly discussed by the rabbis in the time of Jesus (see 10:27).

Luke 18:18–30

The story of the rich religious leader warns against trusting in riches rather than pledging complete allegiance to God.

Luke 18:19

Why do you call Me good?: The man called Jesus *good* as a compliment, but only God is truly good. Jesus challenged the man’s understanding of goodness. True goodness requires moral perfection.

Luke 18:20

You know the commandments: Jesus refers to the fifth through ninth of the Ten Commandments (Exodus 20:12–16; Deuteronomy 5:16–20). These commandments are about relationships between human beings.

Luke 18:21

All these I have kept: The man’s claim to have kept all the commandments shows that he misunderstood the nature of true goodness.

Luke 18:22

The man’s love for his wealth showed he did not fully obey God. He did not love God or others as God requires (10:25–28). Loving wealth is a form of worshiping false gods (idolatry) (Ephesians 5:5; Colossians 3:5).

Luke 18:24–25

How hard it is for the rich to enter the Kingdom of God! Though Scripture sometimes speaks of riches as a blessing from God (2 Chr 1:11–12; Pss 112:3; 128:2; Prov 8:18; Isa 61:6), many passages warn against the danger of trusting riches instead of God (Ps 62:10; Prov 11:28; Jer 9:23–24;

49:4–5). • the eye of a needle: See study note on Mark 10:25. This is not merely difficult, but impossible. No one can be saved while trusting in riches. Salvation comes only by dependence on God (Luke 18:27).

Luke 18:27

The point of this whole event is that salvation is impossible by human effort, but possible by the grace of God.

Luke 18:28–30

we have left all we had to follow You: In contrast to the rich ruler, Peter and the other disciples had given up everything to follow Jesus. Jesus affirmed that they would receive back far more than they had given up.

Luke 18:30

receive many times more in this age: Their reward would not necessarily be physical, but they would enjoy the blessings that come from spiritual wholeness and a right relationship with God.

Luke 18:31

The death of Jesus fulfilled all the predictions of the Old Testament prophets. It was God's plan (Luke 24:25–26, 46; Acts 2:23; 3:18; 4:28).

The main prophecy about the suffering Messiah is in Isaiah 52:13–53:12. Luke also refers to several Old Testament prophecies, including:

- Psalm 2 in Acts 4:25–26,
- Psalm 16 in Acts 2:25–28,
- Psalm 118:22 in Luke 20:17, and
- Isaiah 50:4–9 in Luke 18:32–33.

Luke 18:31–34

This was the last time Jesus predicted his suffering and death before he entered Jerusalem for his final week of ministry (see also 9:22, 44–45; 17:25).

Luke 18:32–33

will be mocked ... will flog Him: See Isaiah 50:6.

Luke 18:34

The disciples did not understand any of these things: The disciples did not understand that the death of Jesus would bring salvation until after he rose from the dead (see 9:45; 24:13–34).

Luke 18:35

Jericho was located in an oasis in the Judean wilderness, 30 kilometers (18 miles) northeast of Jerusalem. At 250 meters

(820 feet) below sea level, it is the world's lowest city and one of the oldest.

Luke 18:35–43

This account again demonstrates Jesus' care for the poor and marginalized in Israel. It reminds the reader that Jesus is the Son of David, the Messiah (18:38), shortly before he enters Jerusalem as king (19:28–44).

Luke 18:38

Son of David is a title for the Messiah, a descendant of David who would reign on David's throne forever (see 1:32–33; 2 Sam 7:11–16; Isa 9:6–7; 11:1–5; Jer 23:5–6; 33:15–16; Ezek 37:24–25).

Luke 19:1–10

The story of Zacchaeus is a fitting climax to Jesus' ministry to the outcasts of Israel on his journey to Jerusalem (9:51–19:44). The final verse of the episode (19:10) is often viewed as the theme verse of Luke's Gospel.

Luke 19:2

The chief tax collector for a particular region leased from the Romans the right to collect taxes, and then oversaw subordinate tax collectors from whom he collected a commission. This situation allowed Zacchaeus to get very rich, and chief tax collectors were hated even more than their subordinates (see study note on 3:12).

Luke 19:4

climbed a sycamore-fig tree: This action was very undignified for a man with the power and wealth of Zacchaeus. It shows that he truly wanted to see and know Jesus.

Luke 19:5

Zacchaeus ... I must stay at your house today: Jesus knew Zacchaeus's name and invited himself to his home. This showed that the authority of Jesus is from God and that this meeting was part of God's plan.

Luke 19:7

The guest of a sinful man: People also criticized Jesus for spending time with sinners, as they did when he was with Levi (5:27–32; see study note on 5:30).

Luke 19:8

I will give them back four times: Normal restitution for a wrong committed was to add twenty percent to the value of the goods lost (Lev 5:16; Num 5:7), though the penalty for theft of an animal was four or five times its value (Exod 22:1).

Zacchaeus apparently regarded his financial gains as theft and promised the required restitution.

Luke 19:9

this man has shown himself to be a true son of Abraham: Zacchaeus was a child of Abraham by descent (a Jew); now he demonstrated faith like Abraham's (see [Rom 4:11–12](#)).

Luke 19:10

to seek and to save the lost: The Lord Jesus is like a shepherd who looks for lost sheep (see [Psalm 23:1](#); [Isaiah 53:6](#); [Jeremiah 13:17](#); [Ezekiel 34](#); [Zechariah 10:3](#); [13:7](#)).

Luke 19:11–27

This *parable* has two main purposes:

1. To teach stewardship. This means managing gifts and resources well while the *man of noble birth* (Jesus) is away (compare [Matthew 25:14–30](#)).
2. To correct the belief that the kingdom of God would start immediately when Jesus entered Jerusalem. Most Jews in the time of Jesus expected that when the Messiah (the Christ) came, God's kingdom would be established physically on earth, with Jerusalem at its center (see [Isaiah 2:2–4](#); [35:1–10](#); [65:17–25](#); [Jeremiah 30–31](#); [Ezekiel 37, 40–48](#); [Micah 4:1–5](#)).

Luke 19:12

A man of noble birth went to a distant country to lay claim to his kingship: This account shows Judea's status as a client kingdom of the Roman Empire. After a king's death, those claiming the right to be king would travel to Rome to seek support. Similarly, Jesus would first leave for heaven to receive his royal authority and later return to rule God's people and judge those who oppose him (see [19:14, 27](#)).

Luke 19:14

his subjects hated him and sent a delegation: This happened to Archelaus, the son of Herod the Great, who violently put down protests after the death of his father. In response, the Jews sent representatives to plead against his kingship before the Roman emperor.

Luke 19:17

you shall have authority over ten cities: Because of the servant's faithfulness, the king gave him a major position in his kingdom. Similarly, those who are faithful to Jesus in this life will receive greater responsibility here and great rewards in heaven.

Luke 19:23

deposit my money in the bank (Literally *put the money on the table*): This means to give it to those lending money who will loan it out for interest.

Luke 19:26

will be given more: Those who are trustworthy with a small amount will receive more (compare [8:18](#)).

Luke 19:27

as for these enemies of mine: Those who reject Jesus' reign as king will suffer his judgment. This part of the parable was directed against the religious leaders. • bring them in and execute them: A new king would often execute his opponents (see [1 Kgs 2:13–46](#); cp. [Ps 2](#)).

Luke 19:28–40

Jesus entered Jerusalem in triumph. This fulfilled [Zechariah 9:9–10](#) and symbolically announced that he was the Messiah, the King of Israel.

Luke 19:29

Bethany was on the eastern slope of the Mount of Olives, two miles east of Jerusalem; it was the home of Lazarus and his sisters, Mary and Martha ([John 11:1, 18](#); [12:1](#); see [Luke 10:38](#)). The location of Bethphage is uncertain, but it was probably near Bethany on the same road from Jericho. • The Mount of Olives overlooks Jerusalem from the east and has significance at the return of Christ (see [Acts 1:11](#); [Zech 14:4](#)).

Luke 19:30

you will see a young donkey: It is unclear whether Jesus had arranged for the donkey ahead of time, or whether he used divine insight. Either way, Jesus' entrance into Jerusalem was a symbolic action. He rode a humble *donkey* rather than a war horse to confirm that he was fulfilling the role of the Messiah by bringing reconciliation and peace ([Zech 9:9–10](#)).

Luke 19:31

The Lord needs it: Subjects of a king were expected to make resources available for his use (see [1 Sam 8:16](#)). The donkey's colt had never been ridden, so it was pure and suitable for a king.

Luke 19:36

The crowds *spread their cloaks* to show respect and honor to this royal figure (see [2 Kings 9:13](#)).

Luke 19:38

Blessings on the King . . . glory in highest heaven! See [Pss 118:26; 148:1](#). [Psalm 118](#) was one of the psalms sung by pilgrims traveling to Jerusalem for one of the festivals ([Pss 113–118](#)). • Jesus brought peace in heaven—reconciliation between God and human beings—but peace on earth awaits the future (cp. [Luke 2:14](#); see [12:51–53](#); [19:41–44](#)).

Luke 19:40

Compare [Isa 55:12](#), in which nature is said to rejoice at the coming of God's salvation, and [Hab 2:11](#), in which the stones of the walls cry out against Babylon.

Luke 19:42

now it is hidden from your eyes: Israel's rejection of Jesus had serious consequences. In this context, the decision was final and could not be reversed.

Luke 19:43–44

Jesus foretold the siege and destruction of Jerusalem by the Romans in AD 70. The Jewish historian Josephus describes the horrific suffering of the inhabitants of Jerusalem during the Roman siege ([War 5.1.1–7.1.1](#)). • will not leave a single stone in place: This is an image of total devastation.

Luke 19:45

Pilgrims coming to worship at the Temple would purchase animals for sacrifices in the Temple courts. Jesus also drove out the money changers who provided the correct currency for the Temple tax ([Matt 21:12](#); [Mark 11:15](#); see [Exod 30:13–16](#); [Neh 10:32–33](#)). While these were necessary services, Jesus objected to the exploitation of the Temple for illicit commercial gain that distracted from its purpose as a place of worship. The Temple was meant to reflect God's glory for all nations, but it had become corrupt.

Luke 19:45–48

Having just entered Jerusalem as the Messiah, Jesus performed a messianic action (cp. [Mal 3:1](#)) by driving money changers and merchants selling animals for sacrifices out of the Temple. This cleansing was to restore true worship to the Temple. It was also symbolic of the judgment that Jesus had just pronounced against Israel ([19:41–44](#)).

Luke 19:47

The clearing of the Temple catalyzed the opposition and precipitated Jesus' crucifixion (but see study note on [Mark 11:12–25](#)). • Jesus' opposition in Galilee came mainly from the Pharisees and teachers of religious law; in Jerusalem, the opposition also included the leading priests, who controlled

the Temple. Jesus' actions against the Temple trade threatened their authority.

Luke 20:1

the chief priests and scribes, together with the elders: These were the most influential Jewish leaders in Jerusalem. They united against Jesus because he threatened their authority.

Luke 20:1–47

In this series of controversies between Jesus and the religious leaders of Jerusalem, they repeatedly questioned and challenged him, and he repeatedly outmatched them with his spiritual wisdom, insight, and authority.

Luke 20:2

by what authority are You doing these things: Since these groups were the recognized Jewish authorities in Jerusalem, they wanted to know how Jesus could claim authority to enter Jerusalem as a king and drive the merchants from the temple.

Luke 20:4–6

The question Jesus asked trapped the religious leaders (see [20:5–6](#)) because either answer would accuse them.

Luke 20:6

the people will stone us: Stoning was the penalty for blasphemy ([Lev 24:14–15](#)), idolatry ([Lev 20:2](#); [Deut 13:10](#)), and other sins of defiance against God. The people might have regarded rejection of an authentic prophet as blasphemy deserving of stoning.

Luke 20:7–8

The Jewish authorities refused to answer Jesus' question, so Jesus had no obligation to answer their question. Both their question and their refusal were guided by self-interest rather than integrity.

Luke 20:9

rented it out to some tenants: This was a common practice in first-century Palestine, especially in Galilee. Many poor farmers would rent land from wealthy owners so they could grow crops.

Luke 20:9–19

This story adapts Isaiah's Song of the Fruitful Vineyard ([Isa 5:1–7](#)) to allegorize Jesus' rejection by Israel's leaders. In Isaiah's allegory, the vineyard owner is God and Israel is the unfruitful vineyard that will be judged. Jesus added new characters—the tenant farmers were Israel's unrighteous leaders, the servants were the Old Testament prophets

(repeatedly rejected by Israel), and the son was Jesus. God would judge Israel's leaders for rejecting and murdering his son.

Luke 20:10

the tenants beat the servant: God's prophets were often mistreated and opposed by the people of Israel (1 Kings 19:10, 14; 2 Chronicles 24:21; 36:16; Nehemiah 9:26; Jeremiah 2:30; 26:20–24; 37:15).

Luke 20:13

my beloved son: The Messiah was predicted to have a unique father-son relationship with God (see 2 Samuel 7:14; Psalms 2:7; 89:26–29).

Luke 20:14

Let us kill him, and the inheritance will be ours: They believed that killing the heir would give them power over the estate. They foolishly failed to realize that the owner was still alive and would demand justice. Similarly, the religious leaders thought that they could keep their authority over the people of Israel by killing Jesus.

Luke 20:17

The stone . . . cornerstone: Jesus cited Ps 118:22 to predict his rejection and restoration. The cornerstone was the key part of a building, used to support and align adjoining walls. Jesus was rejected by the builders (the religious leaders), but he would become the foundation of a new building (the church).

Luke 20:18

Jesus expanded the stone metaphor (20:17) with allusions to Isa 8:14–15 and Dan 2:34, 44–45. Although Israel rejected him, Jesus was the foundation for the new people of God, and he inaugurated a Kingdom that would last forever.

Luke 20:19

realized that Jesus had spoken this parable against them: The story provoked the religious leaders to act it out by arresting and killing Jesus.

Luke 20:20–26

The religious leaders asked this question to trap Jesus, but he answered in a way that avoided their trap.

Luke 20:21

we know that You speak and teach correctly: These dishonest words of praise were meant to trick Jesus (see Psalms 5:9; 12:2–3; 78:36; Proverbs 26:28; 28:23; 29:5; Ezekiel 12:24).

Luke 20:22

Is it lawful for us to pay taxes to Caesar or not?: If Jesus said yes, he would make the people angry, because they hated the burden of Roman taxation. If he said no, he would be accused of rebellion against the Roman authorities.

Luke 20:24

a denarius: This Roman coin had the image and inscription of the emperor Tiberius Caesar (see 3:1) stamped on it.

Luke 20:25

Give to Caesar what is Caesar's: Jesus gave a clever answer. There are two ways to understand this statement. On the surface, he said that the coin belonged to Caesar and should be given to him. But his Jewish listeners also understood that, in the end, nothing truly belongs to Caesar, because everything belongs to God.

Luke 20:27

the Sadducees, who say there is no resurrection: See “The Sadducees” Profile.

Luke 20:28

Moses wrote for us: A dead man's brother would marry the widow to produce children who would maintain the dead man's name and property (Deuteronomy 25:5–6; see also Genesis 38:8–10; Ruth 4:1–12).

Luke 20:29–33

Well, suppose there were seven brothers: A similar story of a woman married to seven husbands appears in the Old Testament Apocrypha (Tobit 3:7–17; 6:10–8:18).

Luke 20:33

in the resurrection, whose wife will she be?: The Sadducees told this made-up story to show that the idea of resurrection (rising from the dead) did not make sense. They wanted people to think that belief in resurrection was foolish.

They likely used this same argument many times. It was a common attack that the Sadducees used when they debated the Pharisees.

Luke 20:35

will neither marry nor be given in marriage: Jesus taught that marriage belongs to this present life on earth. It is not part of life after the resurrection (when the dead rise to life again).

Luke 20:36

In this respect they will be like angels: Angels are not married, and they are immortal. The Bible never teaches that

people become angels (cp. [Heb 1:5–2:18](#)), but that we will be like them.

Luke 20:37

Having refuted the Sadducees' argument about marriage, Jesus turned to the larger question concerning the resurrection. • even Moses proved this: Jesus used the books of Moses (Genesis–Deuteronomy)—the only Scripture the Sadducees recognized as authoritative—to prove the resurrection. • the God of Abraham . . . Jacob: God identified himself as the God of Abraham, Isaac, and Jacob long after these patriarchs had died. Since he was still their God, they must have had a continuing existence after death.

Luke 20:39

Teacher, You have spoken well!: Most teachers of religious law were Pharisees, so they agreed with Jesus on the resurrection and were pleased that he refuted the Sadducees.

Luke 20:40

The wise answers of Jesus confused his opponents. They could not defeat him in argument.

They had tried to trap him with difficult questions. Instead, his replies exposed their motives and showed his wisdom.

As a result, their plans to trap him failed.

Luke 20:41

The Old Testament predicted that the Messiah would be a descendant of King David (see study note on 18:38).

Luke 20:41–44

After Jesus silenced his opponents, he began to challenge the religious leaders and their understanding of the Messiah.

Luke 20:42–43

Jesus quotes [Psalm 110:1](#). By quoting this verse, Jesus shows that the Messiah (God's chosen leader) is more than a descendant of David. The Messiah is also David's Lord.

Luke 20:44

Jesus asked why David addressed his son (i.e., his descendant) as his Lord. The implied answer was that the Messiah was more than just a human king descended from David. He is Lord of all (see [2:11](#); [Acts 10:36](#)). [Psalm 110:1](#) became an important text for the apostles, confirming Jesus' identity as the Son of God (see [Mark 14:62](#); [Acts 2:34](#); [7:56](#); [Rom 8:34](#); [1 Cor 15:25](#); [Eph 1:20](#); [Col 3:1](#); [Heb 1:3](#), [13](#); [8:1](#); [10:12–13](#); [1 Pet 3:22](#); [Rev 3:21](#)).

Luke 20:46–47

Jesus continued on the offensive, warning against the hypocrisy and exploitation of the teachers of religious law. • respectful greetings . . . seats of honor: See study note on 11:43. • head table at banquets: See study notes on 5:30; 14:7.

Luke 20:47

Yet they shamelessly cheat widows: This might mean exploiting widows' property over which they were appointed guardians; it could also mean coercing widows to give money beyond their means. Widows were the most vulnerable members of society, and God had special concern for them. He would judge those who exploited them ([Exod 22:22](#); [Deut 10:18](#); [27:19](#)).

Luke 21:1

The Greek term for *treasury* likely refers to boxes with trumpet-shaped openings for collecting offerings.

Luke 21:1–4

Jesus set the sacrificial offering of the poor widow in contrast to the greed and hypocrisy of the rich people, including the teachers of religious law ([20:45–47](#)).

Luke 21:2

two small copper coins: These coins (Greek *lepta*) were worth about 1/64 of a denarius. A denarius was the wage a laborer would receive for one day of work.

Luke 21:4

The size of the gift matters less than the attitude of the person who gives it.

Luke 21:5

majestic stonework: Herod the Great rebuilt and restored the Jerusalem Temple, producing one of the great structures of the ancient world. According to Josephus, the massive white stones reflected the sun with such brilliance that from a distance the Temple looked like snow-covered mountains ([War 5.5.6](#)). • The memorial decorations were probably funded by offerings given by worshipers to fulfill vows.

Luke 21:5–38

When Jesus predicted the destruction of the Temple of Jerusalem ([21:6](#)), his disciples questioned when it would take place and what signs would accompany it ([21:7](#)). Jesus responded by describing the events surrounding the destruction of the Temple and the return of the Son of Man ([21:8–36](#)). This sermon is known as the Olivet Discourse because the Mount of Olives was the site of Jesus' teaching (see [Matt 24:3](#); [Mark 13:3](#)).

Luke 21:6

not one stone will be left on another: See study note on 19:43–44.

Luke 21:8

claiming, ‘I am He.’: See study note on Mark 13:5–6.

Luke 21:8–11

Jesus spoke about events that many people misunderstand as signs of the end of the age. These events include false messiahs (people who claim to be God’s chosen one), wars, earthquakes, famines (times when there is not enough food), and severe persecution (violent suffering because of faith).

However, Jesus made it clear that these events do not mean the end will happen right away. The end will not come immediately after these things.

Luke 21:11

Cataclysmic events such as these are often associated with the judgment of God (1 Sam 14:15; Ps 18:7–8; Isa 2:19, 21; 5:25; 13:13; 24:18; 29:5–6; Jer 14:12; 21:6–7; Ezek 14:21; Amos 1:1) and the end of the age (Isa 24:18; 29:5–6; Ezek 38:19; Joel 2:10; Hag 2:6, 21; Zech 14:4; cp. Rev 6:12; 8:5; 11:13, 19; 16:18). • great miraculous signs from heaven: See study note on 21:25.

Luke 21:12

dragged into synagogues: Jesus and his early followers were Jewish, and the earliest conflicts were with fellow Jews who did not accept Jesus as the Messiah. Jesus’ followers were sometimes tried in the synagogue before a Jewish tribunal (cp. 2 Cor 11:24).

Luke 21:12–19

a time of great persecution: Jesus described the persecution that his followers would experience (see also Matt 10:17–22; Mark 13:9). The Jewish literature of Jesus’ day similarly described a time of great tribulation prior to the arrival of God’s final salvation.

Luke 21:15

I will give you the right words: God often assured his prophets that he would give them the words to say (Exod 4:12, 15; Deut 18:18; Isa 50:4; 51:16; Jer 1:9). Jesus’ disciples were to prepare themselves to be clear witnesses (see Col 4:5–6; 2 Tim 2:21; 1 Pet 3:15), knowing that the Spirit would help them to respond as powerfully as Jesus had done (Luke 20:20–44).

Luke 21:16

Families in Jewish and Gentile communities have often been divided as some members follow Jesus and some reject him.

Luke 21:18–19

But not a hair of your head will perish! This idiom signifies full protection (1 Sam 14:45; 2 Sam 14:11; 1 Kgs 1:52; Dan 3:27). It refers here to the disciples’ souls, because some would be martyred for their faith (Luke 21:16).

Luke 21:20–24

Jesus was describing the siege and destruction of Jerusalem that would take place in AD 70.

Luke 21:21

those in the city get out: Because of this prophecy, Christians in Judea fled to the town of Pella in Decapolis before the destruction of Jerusalem in AD 70 (Eusebius, *Church History* 3.5).

Luke 21:22

these are the days of vengeance: The destruction of Jerusalem was part of God’s judgment for Israel’s rejection of the Messiah.

Luke 21:24

until the times of the Gentiles are fulfilled: Daniel predicted that a series of Gentile empires (kingdoms ruled by non-Jews) would come before God’s kingdom (Daniel 2:44; 7:27).

Luke 21:25

The prophets predicted that *signs* in the sky would come before God’s judgment at the end of time (Isaiah 13:9–10; 34:4; Jeremiah 4:23, 28; Ezekiel 32:7–8; Joel 2:10, 30–31; compare Revelation 6:13–14; 8:10; 9:1; 12:1, 3; 15:1).

Luke 21:31

All these things refer to the events described in 21:25–30.

Luke 21:32

this generation will not pass from the scene: This saying is puzzling—Jesus seems to have predicted that he would come again before the first generation of his disciples died out. There are three main interpretations: (1) the reference is to the destruction of Jerusalem in AD 70 when Jesus “came” in judgment against the nation of Israel; (2) “this generation” is not Jesus’ contemporaries, but a future generation alive when these signs begin coming to fulfillment; (3) the term *generation* could be translated “race,” referring to the Jewish race that will not disappear before Christ returns.

Luke 21:33

Heaven and earth will pass away: See study note on 16:17.

Luke 21:34

The main theme of this teaching is, “Watch out!” Believers must always stay alert and be ready for Christ’s return.

Luke 21:36

to stand before: This means to “pass the test” and stand approved before Jesus Christ at his second coming.

Luke 22:1

The Passover meal was held on the 15th of Nisan (March–April) in the Jewish calendar and was immediately followed by the seven-day Festival of Unleavened Bread ([Exod 12:1–20](#); [23:15](#); [34:18](#); [Deut 16:1–8](#)), sometimes also called Passover.

Luke 22:1–6

The religious leaders who had been plotting against Jesus (see [19:47](#)) found their opportunity when Judas Iscariot approached them with an offer to betray Jesus.

Luke 22:3

Satan entered Judas Iscariot: See [John 13:2](#); [Acts 5:3](#). Earlier, Satan had tempted Jesus and had been waiting for this opportunity ([Luke 4:2, 13](#)).

Luke 22:4

temple officers: These were leaders within the temple’s own security force. The temple had its own police force to keep order and protect the sacred area.

Luke 22:5

Judas wanted the *money*. Judas wanted the money. John says that he was a thief and used to steal from the money bag of the disciples ([John 12:6](#)).

Luke 22:6

in the absence of a crowd: They waited until the crowds were not present. They did this because Jesus was very popular with the people.

The leaders were afraid of how the crowd might react if they arrested him in public.

Luke 22:7

The Passover lamb was killed at twilight (the time between sunset and darkness). The Passover meal was then eaten that same evening (see [Exodus 12:6–8](#)).

Luke 22:7–30

Jesus celebrated the traditional Jewish Passover but transformed it with reference to his own sacrificial death as the Passover lamb. He also prepared his disciples for his coming death and the leadership role they would assume over his church.

Luke 22:8

Go and prepare the Passover meal: The lamb was roasted and eaten with bitter herbs and unleavened bread at the Passover meal ([Exod 12:8](#); [Num 9:11–12](#); [Deut 16:3](#)). The bitter herbs represented the bitterness of the Israelites’ slavery in Egypt, and the unleavened bread recalled their haste in leaving Egypt.

Luke 22:10

a man carrying a jug of water: This was unusual because women usually carried the water.

Luke 22:11–12

The text does not say whether Jesus knew about the room because of his divine nature or if he had made arrangements for this room ahead of time (see also [19:30–34](#)).

Luke 22:14

Jesus reclined at the table: The Jewish people adopted the Greek custom of reclining on couches next to tables at banquets (see study note on [John 13:23](#)).

Luke 22:15

Jesus ate the Passover meal with his disciples and followed the ritual order of the Passover celebration (see study note on [Matthew 26:26–29](#)).

Luke 22:16

until its meaning is fulfilled in the Kingdom of God: This celebration had as its goal the messianic banquet (see [14:1–24](#)). Jesus’ death as the true Passover lamb ([1 Cor 5:7](#)) inaugurated the Kingdom of God that will be completed at Jesus’ second coming.

Luke 22:17

he took a cup of wine: The traditional Passover celebration used four cups of wine—at the opening benediction, after the Passover explanation, after the meal, and after a concluding psalm. This was probably the first cup that introduced the ceremony.

Luke 22:19–20

Using the bread and cup as symbols of his body and blood, Jesus instituted the communion service that the disciples

were to practice in remembrance of his death. • This is my body, which is given for you: The unleavened bread of the Passover symbolized Jesus' death as the Passover lamb. His death would pay for the sins of the world (cp. [1 Cor 11:24–25](#)).

Luke 22:20

God's covenants in the Old Testament were confirmed with the blood of a sacrifice ([Gen 15:9–10](#); [Exod 24:8](#)). Jesus' death established the new covenant that God had promised his people ([Jer 31:31–34](#)).

Luke 22:21–22

it has been determined: Wicked men betrayed and killed Jesus, but this took place as part of God's purposeful plan to bring salvation (see [Acts 2:23](#)).

Luke 22:22

woe to that man who betrays Him: Judas suffered guilt, judgment, and a terrible death for betraying Jesus ([Matthew 27:5](#); [Acts 1:18](#)).

Luke 22:24

which of them should be considered the greatest: See also [Mark 9:33–37](#) and [10:35–45](#).

Luke 22:25

benefactors: This translates a Greek word that refers to the practice of rulers bestowing gifts and favors on their subjects to gain loyalty and honor. Jesus contrasted this worldly style of leadership (military power, coercion, and bribery) with his own servant leadership in giving himself for others.

Luke 22:27

For I am among you as one who serves: Jesus defined true leadership as service—meeting the needs of others and empowering them to be all that God has called them to be (see [Mark 10:45](#)). This statement was striking in a culture for which status and power were central.

Luke 22:29–30

you may eat and drink at My table: See “The Messianic Banquet” Theme Note.

Luke 22:30

you will sit on thrones, judging the twelve tribes of Israel: This could be a figurative reference to the apostles' leadership in the church, or it could indicate their special role in the future when the Kingdom would be consummated on earth (cp. [Eph 2:20](#); [Rev 3:21](#); [20:4](#)).

Luke 22:31

Regarding Satan, see [4:2](#); [10:18](#); [11:15](#). Satan is the accuser of God's people (see [Job 1:7](#); [2:2](#)); he would test Simon Peter and the rest of the apostles. • asked to sift: Wheat was sifted through a sieve to separate the grain from the chaff. It is an image of extreme testing (see [Isa 30:28](#); [Amos 9:9](#)). • The NLT's each of you is precise, because the Greek *you* is plural, referring to all the disciples. Jesus foresaw Peter's denial and the trials of the other disciples.

Luke 22:32

when you have turned back: The *you* here is singular and refers to Peter's restoration after he denied Jesus.

Luke 22:33

See [Acts 4:3](#); [5:18](#); [12:1–9](#), where Peter suffered trials and was repeatedly jailed. Church tradition relates that Peter was crucified in Rome, but his declaration of loyalty here was premature.

Luke 22:34

On Thursday evening, Jesus said that Peter would deny him before the rooster crows tomorrow morning (literally *before the rooster crows today*): This does not contradict Mark's “this very night, before the rooster crows twice” ([Mark 14:30](#)); Luke and Matthew are simply more general, and in Jewish reckoning, sunset was the beginning of the next day.

Luke 22:36

take your money and a traveler's bag: For their missions to Israel's villages, the apostles had traveled without provisions and depended on others' support ([9:3](#); [10:3–4](#)). In the dangerous days to come, they would have to plan more carefully. Jesus prepared his disciples for his suffering and death, and also for the establishing of the church and the worldwide proclamation of the Good News. • a sword: Jesus was probably not telling his followers to take up arms, but was speaking metaphorically—they must prepare themselves for a violent crisis.

Luke 22:38

That's enough: The disciples' two swords were probably not enough to defend the whole group, and Jesus elsewhere rejected violence ([22:49–51](#) // [Matt 26:52](#)). Jesus might have meant that two swords were sufficient to fulfill [Isa 53:12](#). Or perhaps he meant, “Enough of this foolish talk—you are misunderstanding me.”

Luke 22:39

Mount of Olives: See study note on 19:29. This was the location of the garden of Gethsemane (see [Matthew 26:36](#); [Mark 14:32](#)).

Luke 22:42

take this cup from Me: A cup is a metaphor for experiencing either judgment or blessing (see, for example, [Psalms 23:5](#); [75:8](#); [116:13](#); [Isaiah 51:17](#)). Jesus felt all the emotions of his humanity, including fear and anxiety.

Luke 22:43

an angel from heaven: Angels often help and encourage human beings (see [Hebrews 1:14](#); compare [1 Kings 19:5–8](#); [Psalm 91:11–12](#); [Daniel 3:28](#); [10:16–19](#)).

Luke 22:44

His sweat became like drops of blood falling to the ground: The text does not say that Jesus sweated blood, as people often think. It says that his sweat fell to the ground like blood. This probably means that, in his agony, he was sweating very heavily.

Luke 22:45–46

Jesus prayed in great distress, while the disciples failed to remain alert against temptation.

Luke 22:47

A kiss was a common way for friends to greet each other. Judas's kiss made his betrayal even more clear.

Luke 22:51

he touched the man's ear and healed him: John tells us that the man's name was Malchus and that Peter was the one who cut off his ear ([John 18:10](#)). Peter probably thought that he was precipitating the final war and that the heavenly host was about to appear and destroy the Romans. When Jesus refused to fight, the terror-stricken disciples fled ([Matt 26:56](#) // [Mark 14:50](#)).

Luke 22:52

The Greek word translated revolutionary normally means "thief," but the Romans used this term for violent revolutionaries who opposed Roman authority (such as Barabbas, [23:18–19](#)). To patriotic Jews, they were freedom fighters; to the Romans, they were common thugs.

Luke 22:54

The high priest's home might have been the home of Caiaphas, the current high priest, or Annas, his father-in-

law and a previous high priest (see study note on [3:2](#); [John 18:12–14](#)).

Luke 22:59

for he too is a Galilean: Peter's way of speaking made it clear that he was from Galilee (compare [Judges 12:5–6](#)).

Luke 22:61

the Lord turned and looked at Peter: At that time, Jesus was inside the house, where the leaders were questioning him. He may have looked through a window or an open entryway (a covered space at the entrance of a house).

When their eyes met, the rooster crowed. Then Peter remembered what Jesus had said earlier, that Peter would deny him ([22:34](#)).

Luke 22:63

began to mock Him and beat Him: See [18:32](#); [Isaiah 50:6](#); [53:3–5](#).

Luke 22:64

Prophesy! Who hit You?: Jesus had a reputation as a prophet ([4:24](#); [7:16](#), [39](#); [13:33](#); [24:19](#)), so the soldiers mocked this claim.

Luke 22:66

At daybreak: It was Friday morning (see study note on [22:34](#)). • all the elders of the people assembled: The Jewish high council (Greek *Sanhedrin*) was originally made up of the Jerusalem nobility, both civil leaders and priests, with the high priest as its head. In Jesus' time, the Sadducees still controlled the Sanhedrin ([Acts 5:17](#)), though leading Pharisees had also gained a prominent place on the council ([Acts 23:7](#)).

Luke 22:67–68

If I tell you, you won't believe me: Jesus pointed out the hypocrisy of the question. They had already made up their minds that he was not the Messiah, so it would do no good to answer.

Luke 22:69

Jesus referred to [Ps 110:1](#) (cp. [Luke 20:42–43](#)). Though he would be crucified, Jesus would be vindicated through his resurrection and exalted to God's right hand (see [Acts 2:33–36](#); cp. [Dan 7:13–14](#)). Furthermore, he would be seated in the place of power as Judge. Jesus would soon sit in judgment over those who were trying him.

Luke 22:70

The significance of Jesus' statement (22:69) was not lost on the council members. The Messiah was expected to be the Son of God and have a special father-son relationship with God (see study notes on 1:32–33; 4:41; cp. 2 Sam 7:14; Pss 2:7; 89:26). The Sanhedrin accused Jesus of claiming to be the Messiah (cp. study notes on Mark 14:62, 63–64). • You say that I am: This is a qualified affirmation. Jesus probably meant, "What you say is true, but you do not understand what 'Messiah' means." They understood it as a confirmation (Luke 22:71).

Luke 22:71

Why do we need other witnesses? The high council regarded Jesus' confirmation that he was both the Messiah and the Son of God as a blasphemous claim and thus as proof of his guilt.

Luke 23:1

The council did not have the right to administer capital punishment (John 18:31), so they had to take Jesus before the Roman governor, who was in Jerusalem to maintain order during the potentially turbulent Passover festival.

Luke 23:2

The religious charges against Jesus were now replaced by political ones in order to gain a Roman conviction. Pilate was only interested in what concerned Rome. The Jewish charge of blasphemy would not be sufficient, so the council had to show that Jesus was a danger to Rome. They accused Jesus of inciting insurrection against Roman taxation and claiming to be a king. All but the last charge were false.

Luke 23:3

You have said it: This is the same vague answer that Jesus gave to the high council (22:70), emphasizing Jesus' acceptance of the title "king of the Jews" but suggesting that Pilate's understanding of the title was different from his own.

Luke 23:4

I find no basis for a charge against this man: Jesus did not appear to be a political threat to Pilate.

Luke 23:5

He stirs up the people: This accusation was also false, but the religious leaders knew that Pilate feared civil unrest and revolt against Rome.

Luke 23:6–7

Pilate realized that Jesus was from Galilee and was under the authority of Herod Antipas. This gave Pilate a way to avoid the situation without condemning an innocent man or upsetting the religious leaders.

Luke 23:8

he was greatly pleased: He was curious about Jesus and his power to do miracles and teach, just as he had been curious about John the Baptist (9:7, 9; Mark 6:20).

Luke 23:9

He gave no answer: See Isaiah 53:7.

Luke 23:12

they had been enemies: There was a history of conflict between Herod Antipas and Pilate. Herod and three of his brothers had earlier accused Pilate before Tiberius Caesar. This happened when Pilate placed gold shields with pagan symbols in Jerusalem, and Tiberius ordered him to remove them.

Pilate also ruled Judea, a region that Herod Antipas's father, Herod the Great, had once ruled. Antipas hoped that he might one day rule this area himself.

Luke 23:14–15

Pilate and Herod repeatedly declared Jesus innocent (23:4, 22). Jesus was the righteous and innocent servant who suffered for the Lord (see also 23:41, 47; Isaiah 53:11).

Luke 23:16–18

I will have him flogged (or I will teach him a lesson!): The Greek word can mean "instruct," "punish," or "discipline"; it refers to a relatively mild whipping given for lesser offenses. It was different from the severe flogging that Romans gave in preparation for crucifixion (see Matt 27:26; Mark 15:15).

Luke 23:19

Palestine was a breeding ground for insurrection in the decades leading up to the Jewish revolt of AD 66–74. The Jewish historian Josephus describes a series of first-century revolutionaries, such as Judas of Galilee, who opposed Roman rule and taxation (see also Acts 5:36–37).

Luke 23:24

So Pilate sentenced Jesus to die: Pilate, always the ruthless pragmatist, felt that it was worth a miscarriage of justice to avoid antagonizing the religious leaders and crowds and jeopardizing his political career (see John 19:12 and corresponding study note).

Luke 23:26

Simon might have been a Jewish pilgrim visiting Jerusalem for Passover. • put the cross on him: Prisoners bound for crucifixion were normally forced to carry the crossbeam to the place of execution. It was fastened to the upright beam at the crucifixion site.

Luke 23:28

Jesus warned about the terrible things that would happen to Jerusalem during its siege and destruction in AD 70.

Luke 23:29

Fortunate indeed are the women who are childless: Childlessness was normally a cause of great shame (see study note on 1:7), but during this catastrophe, those who didn't have to see their children starve to death would be the fortunate ones.

Luke 23:30

'they will say to the mountains, "Fall on us!"': This refers to a time when people would prefer death over the terrible suffering they would face. Jesus warned that Jerusalem would experience such terrible pain and destruction that people would beg for mountains to fall on them to end their suffering quickly.

Luke 23:31

If the Romans crucified an innocent man when the tree was green (i.e., during a period of relative peace), what more horrible things would they do when it was dry (i.e., when the land had become a tinderbox of revolution)? During the siege of Jerusalem (AD 66–70), the Romans crucified thousands of Jews outside the city of Jerusalem.

Luke 23:33

The Skull: Greek *kranion*; the Aramaic term is *Golgotha* ([Matt 27:33](#); [Mark 15:22](#)). The location is uncertain, but it has traditionally been associated with the present Church of the Holy Sepulchre. A less likely location is Gordon's Calvary, a rock outcrop near the Garden Tomb. • they nailed him to the cross: Victims were often tied to the cross or nailed through the wrists and ankles to hasten death—here, the bodies had to be buried before sunset due to the approaching Sabbath.

Luke 23:34

by casting lots (see [John 19:23–24](#)): The prisoner's possessions were treated as spoils of war and divided among the soldiers.

Luke 23:35

The crowd watched and the leaders scoffed (see [Ps 22:7–8](#)): [Psalm 22](#) speaks of David, a righteous sufferer, crying out to God for protection. Jesus, David's descendant, was the ultimate righteous sufferer who fulfilled [Ps 22](#).

Luke 23:36

sour wine: This was a popular drink of the lower classes, especially among soldiers (compare [Psalm 69:21](#)).

Luke 23:38

The sign confirmed that Jesus was crucified on the charge of claiming to be the King of the Jews (compare [John 19:19–22](#)).

Luke 23:42

remember me when You come into Your kingdom!: The criminal was perhaps thinking of the resurrection at the end of time, when Jesus would be raised up and vindicated by God.

Luke 23:43

Jesus corrected the man by assuring him that today he would be vindicated in God's presence (see also [2:11](#); [4:21](#); [5:26](#); [19:9](#)). • The word translated paradise comes from a Persian word that means "garden"; it was used in Jewish literature for the Garden of Eden and also for heaven, the place of eternal bliss for God's people (see [2 Cor 12:4](#); [Rev 2:7](#); cp. [Luke 16:22–23](#); [2 Cor 5:8](#)).

Luke 23:44

Darkness symbolizes sorrow as well as God's judgment ([Psalm 23:4](#); [Isaiah 8:22](#); [9:1–2](#)).

Luke 23:45

the curtain in the sanctuary of the Temple: One curtain separated the Temple courtyard from the Holy Place, and another separated the Holy Place from the Most Holy Place. Luke does not say which was torn down the middle, but it was probably the latter—Jesus' death put an end to the sacrificial system of the Temple and opened a new and permanent way into the presence of God (see [Heb 10:19–20](#)).

Luke 23:46

Father, into Your hands I commit My Spirit (see [Psalm 31:5](#)): [Psalm 31](#) is another psalm about a righteous sufferer (a person who suffers but remains faithful to God; see study note on Luke 23:35).

Luke 23:47

righteous (compare [Mark 15:39](#)): Compare [Luke 23:14–15](#). The innocent and righteous servant of the Lord died as a sacrifice for the sins of his people ([Isaiah 53:11](#)).

Luke 23:48

they returned home beating their breasts: This was a sign of sorrow and mourning.

Luke 23:50–51

- Not all the religious leaders opposed Jesus. Joseph had disagreed with the decision of the council.
- The exact location of Arimathea in Judea is unknown. It may have been Ramathaim, or Ramah, about 32 kilometers (20 miles) northwest of Jerusalem.

Luke 23:52

He went to Pilate to ask for the body of Jesus: The Romans used crucifixion as a public warning against revolt, so they did not generally allow a victim to be buried. Instead, they left the body exposed or rotting on the cross. An exception was made in this case, probably because Pilate knew that Jesus was innocent and because of Joseph's position of honor on the Jewish high council.

Luke 23:53

The new tomb had probably been purchased by Joseph as a family tomb.

Luke 23:54

- *Preparation Day:* This happened late on Friday afternoon. The Greek text does not specifically mention Friday. It refers to the day Jews prepare for the Sabbath day ceremonies during Passover week. The Sabbath day begins on Friday evening.
- As the Sabbath was about to begin, they had to bury the body quickly. The Jews could not work during the Sabbath, which began at sunset.

Luke 23:55–56

The women took special note of the tomb's location because they would return with spices and ointments to anoint his body. The spices were to mask the stench of a rotting corpse. A body would be placed on a stone bench in the side of the tomb until the flesh decomposed. The bones would then be collected and placed in a small ossuary, or bone box, and placed on a shelf in the tomb. In this way, a tomb could be used for many family members over an extended period of time.

Luke 24:1

On the first day of the week: The early church worshiped on the first day of the week (Sunday) instead of the seventh (Saturday, the Sabbath) because Jesus rose on a Sunday morning (compare [Acts 20:7](#); [Revelation 1:10](#)).

Luke 24:1–12

Women were the first to find the tomb empty and to hear the announcement of the resurrection. This is strong evidence for the historicity of the resurrection accounts. In first-century Judaism, women were not regarded as reliable witnesses, so the church would never have created stories in which women discovered the empty tomb.

Luke 24:2

The stone was probably a large round stone that was rolled down a track to cover the tomb's entrance.

Luke 24:4

suddenly two men ... stood beside them: Angels often appear as young men in the Bible ([Genesis 18:2](#); [19:1, 10](#); [Joshua 5:13](#); [Judges 13:6–11](#); [Hebrews 13:2](#)). *Radiant apparel* (bright, shining clothes) is a symbol of purity and holiness ([Daniel 10:5–6](#); [Acts 1:10](#); [Revelation 4:4](#); [19:14](#)).

Luke 24:5–7

Jesus had told his followers many times that he would rise from the dead (see [9:22, 44](#); [17:25](#); [18:31–34](#)). The resurrection of Jesus is a key belief of the Christian faith (see [1 Corinthians 15:3–7, 12–57](#)).

Luke 24:7

Jesus rose on the third day, counting Friday as the first day and Sunday as the third.

Luke 24:9

the Eleven: These were the Twelve disciples minus Judas. Judas Iscariot had betrayed Jesus and was no longer with them.

Luke 24:10

Mary Magdalene and Joanna are mentioned in [8:2–3](#). Mary the mother of James is not the mother of James, the son of Zebedee (see [Matt 27:56](#)), but might be the mother of James, the son of Alphaeus ([Luke 6:15](#)).

Luke 24:12

Peter ... ran to the tomb: John went with him ([John 20:2–9](#)).

Luke 24:13

two of Jesus' followers: Jesus had many disciples in addition to the Twelve (see [10:1, 17](#)). Nothing else is known of Cleopas ([24:18](#)) or the other disciple (who may have been his wife). They were probably returning from celebrating the Passover in Jerusalem.

Luke 24:13–34

This account is Luke's unique contribution to the resurrection narratives. Jesus corrected these disciples' misunderstanding by showing from Scripture that it was necessary for the Messiah to suffer. He then opened their eyes to the truth of his resurrection.

Luke 24:16

were kept from recognizing Him: The Greek text uses a passive construction here. This is called a “divine passive” (a way of speaking that shows God is acting, even when God is not named). So here, even though the sentence does not name God as the one acting, the meaning is that God is the one who prevented them from recognizing Jesus. God chose not to let them see who he was until the moment he revealed himself, when Jesus broke bread with them (24:30–31; compare 2 Kings 6:17).

Luke 24:18

Are You the only visitor to Jerusalem who does not know the things: The Romans carried out crucifixions at busy public crossroads to make an example of the victims and warn others not to rebel. For these disciples, it was hard to imagine that a visitor in Jerusalem for Passover (a major Jewish festival) would not have heard about the crucifixion of Jesus.

Luke 24:19

Jesus is often portrayed as a prophet in Luke's Gospel (see 7:16; compare with the description of Moses in Acts 7:22).

Luke 24:21

we were hoping He was the One who would redeem Israel: This refers to the Messiah. The crucifixion had ended their hopes.

Luke 24:22

some of our women astounded us: See 24:10–11.

Luke 24:25–26

The prophets wrote that the Christ (the Messiah, God's chosen king) would have to suffer. The crucifixion did not show that Jesus was not the Christ. Instead, it confirmed that he is the Christ, because Scripture had already said that the Christ would suffer and die. Jesus corrected the two disciples because they did not understand from Scripture that this had to happen (see Isaiah 50:4–9; 52:13–53:12; Psalms 2, 16, 22, 118; compare Luke 18:32; 20:17; 23:37; Acts 2:25–28; 4:25–26).

Luke 24:27

all the Scriptures: This means all of the Old Testament. The Scriptures point forward to the coming of Jesus the Messiah and the salvation that he would bring.

Luke 24:29

they pleaded with Him, “Stay with us”: In Middle Eastern culture, hospitality (kindness to guests) required people to offer food and a place to stay, even to a stranger (Genesis 18:3; 19:2; Judges 19:5–9).

Luke 24:30

- *He was reclining at the table with them:* The meal is a symbol of the messianic banquet (the future feast when God's chosen king gathers his people) and of the salvation that God is bringing about (Isaiah 25:6–8; Luke 14:1–24).
- *and broke it, and gave it to them:* This action recalls the feeding of the 5,000 (9:16) and the institution of the Lord's Supper (22:19).

Luke 24:31

- *Their eyes were opened:* This is another example of the “divine passive” (a way of speaking that shows God is acting, even when he is not named; see study note on 24:16). God opened their eyes when Jesus broke the bread. This means they were finally able to recognize Jesus.
- *and He disappeared from their sight:* In his resurrected and transformed body, Jesus showed abilities he had not shown before the resurrection (see 24:36; 1 Corinthians 15:20–23, 35–57).

Luke 24:34

Simon: The Gospels do not describe this appearance to Simon Peter, but Paul also confirms it in 1 Corinthians 15:5.

Luke 24:39

a spirit does not have flesh and bones, as you see I have: After rising from the dead, Jesus was not a spirit without a body. He had a real body that could never die again or decay. Believers will receive similar bodies at the final resurrection (1 Corinthians 15:35–57).

Luke 24:44

in the Law of Moses, the Prophets, and the Psalms: Jesus referred to the three sections of the Hebrew Scriptures: the Law, the Prophets, and the Writings. The entire Old Testament points to God's salvation through Christ.

Luke 24:46

The Christ will suffer and rise from the dead: See study note on 24:25–26.

Luke 24:47

repentance and forgiveness of sins will be proclaimed to all nations: See [Isaiah 42:6](#); [49:6](#); [Joel 2:28–32](#); [Amos 9:11–12](#); [Acts 2:17–21](#); [13:47](#); [15:16–18](#).

Luke 24:48

The primary role of the apostles in the book of Acts was to be witnesses to the fulfillment of Scripture in the life, death, and resurrection of Jesus (see [Acts 1:8](#)).

Luke 24:49

I am sending the promise of My Father: The Old Testament prophesied that God would pour out his Holy Spirit on all people ([Isaiah 32:15](#); [Jeremiah 31:33](#); [Ezekiel 36:26–27](#); [Joel 2:28–32](#)). This prophecy came true on the day of Pentecost ([Acts 2:14–21](#)).

Luke 24:50

Bethany: See study note on 19:29. See also [Acts 1:11–12](#); [Zechariah 14:4](#).

Luke 24:50–53

Luke also tells about the ascension of Jesus (his return to heaven) in [Acts 1:1–11](#). For Luke, this event showed that God had:

- vindicated Jesus (proved that he was right),
- exalted him (lifted him to the highest place), and
- seated him at his right hand as Messiah (God’s chosen king) and Lord (the one with full authority; [Acts 2:24–36](#)).

From this place of glory and authority in heaven, Jesus leads and guides his church.

Luke 24:51

Compare [2 Kings 2:11](#). The ascension of Jesus marked his exaltation to a position of authority over all creation (see [Acts 2:32–36](#); [5:31](#); [Ephesians 1:19–23](#); [Philippians 2:9–11](#); [Hebrews 1:13](#)).

Luke 24:53

the temple: This was a place for worship and sacrifice. The apostles continued in their Jewish manner of worship because their goal was not to create a new religion but to announce the fulfillment of Scripture’s promises of salvation through Jesus the Messiah.